



KARNATAKA TRANSITION

Siddaramaiah bows out of poll politics

SOUTH » PAGE 7



'VICTORY PARADE'

Thousands rally in Mumbai, slam E20 push

NEWS » PAGE 11



KARGIL VIJAY DIVAS

Talks with Pak. only on PoK, says Rajnath

NEWS » PAGE 12

WILL OF THE PEOPLE

Youth at the vanguard

The resoluteness of the student protests forced the govt. to step back

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



PERFECT FINISH

Sooryavanshi shines, India wins final T20I

SPORT » PAGE 15

NEARBY



2 killed in blast at illegal fireworks shed in Sivakasi

SIVAKASI
Two workers were killed and another suffered 75% burn injuries in an explosion at an illegal fireworks shed near Sengamalapatti in Sivakasi on Sunday. A search is under way for two persons, who according to their relatives' claims also worked at the shed. » PAGE 6



AI to expedite building plan approvals in T.N.

CHENNAI
The State government is in the process of developing a software powered by AI to expedite the building plan approval process. According to sources, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has directed officials to ensure building plan approvals are processed without delay. » PAGE 6

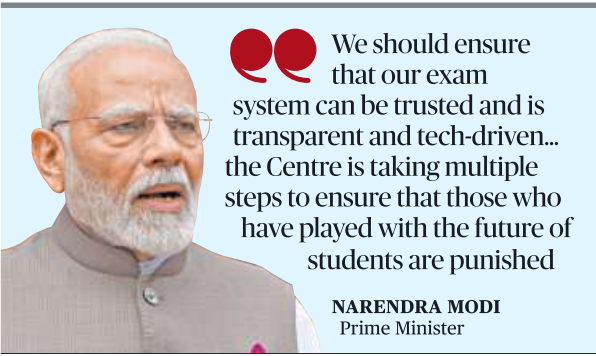
EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 5

Nilekani to lead high-powered task force on exam reforms: PM

It will recommend steps to make exam system leak-proof and technology-driven; former ISRO Chairman Somanath, IIT-M Director Kamakoti among members; Pralhad Joshi takes charge as Union Education Minister; chairs review meeting

Nistula Hebbar
Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday announced the constitution of a high-powered task force, to be headed by former UIDAI Chairman Nandan Nilekani, to recommend steps to make the country's examination system leak-proof and technology-driven. The announcement came a day after former Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned following widespread protests over the NEET paper leak and subsequent re-examination. Meanwhile, Union Minister Pralhad Joshi on Sunday officially took charge of the Ministry of Education at Kartavya Bhavan. Mr. Joshi, who also holds the portfolios of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, and New and Renewable Energy, chaired a meeting of the Ministry to review the implementation of various schemes and other initiatives. "We should ensure that our exam system can be trusted, and is transparent and tech-driven. Under the



leadership of renowned technology expert Nandan Nilekani, a high-powered task force will be formed, which will focus on exam reforms," Mr. Modi said in a video posted on Instagram. "The Centre is taking multiple steps to ensure that those who have played with the future of students are punished. We have already announced the formation of fast-track courts. We are bringing a stringent law in Parliament on Monday," he said.

'Compromised image'
Responding to the announcement, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh said the Centre was yet to implement the K. Radhakrishnan Committee's 101 recommendations after the 2024 examination

We should ensure that our exam system can be trusted and is transparent and tech-driven... the Centre is taking multiple steps to ensure that those who have played with the future of students are punished

NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister

leaks. "This is ultimately only a high-powered attempt to fix the *Pradhan Mantri's* irretrievably compromised image," he said in a post on X. The multidisciplinary panel of domain experts will help revamp the National Testing Agency's examination system, especially from a technology perspective, sources said, adding the committee under Mr. Nilekani will consist of former ISRO Chairman S. Somanath, former IB Director Tapan Deka, IIT-Madras Director V. Kamakoti, former Education Secretary Anita Karwal, and logistics expert Amrit Lal Meena.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
RELATED REPORTS ON
» PAGES 10 & 11

Rahul questions Shah over 'barbaric assault' in Delhi

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Seeking accountability for the "barbaric assault" on students during the march in Delhi on July 20, Rahul Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, has asked Union Home Minister Amit Shah whether he had authorised the use of "lethal force". In a letter

written to the Minister, the Congress leader noted that the students were demanding a fair education system. But, instead of being heard, security forces assaulted them with indiscriminate force and lethal weapons, he said, also noting the alleged use of pellet guns.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 11

Tejashwi demands release of protesters held in Bihar

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Lashing out at the Bihar Police for the arrest of hundreds during a State-wide bandh on Saturday, the State's Leader of the Opposition, Tejashwi Yadav, on Sunday called for the immediate release of students, Opposition MLAs, and

other protesters, including his elder brother Tej Pratap Yadav.

He warned the State government that more people would hit the streets once again in protest, if those held are not released within 24 hours.

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 10

Centre warns Indian seafarers about jobs in 'volatile' Black Sea

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The External Affairs Ministry on Sunday issued an advisory urging Indian seafarers to "carefully assess security risks" before accepting jobs on commercial ships that operate "in and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas", citing increasing drone and missile attacks on ships in the region that remains highly volatile due to the ongoing conflict between Russia and Ukraine.

Earlier, the Indian Embassy in Ukraine said it was "closely monitoring" the situation after a projectile hit the *MV AGN Ragnar* in Ukraine's Black Sea port of Odesa on Saturday. The ship employed four Indian seafarers, of whom two have been found to be safe while information about the other two is still awaited.

There has been an increase in the number of such incidents since April, resulting in the deaths of five Indian seafarers, the Ministry said. "Indian nationals intending to undertake employment on commercial vessels operating in or transiting the conflict-affected region are advised to carefully assess the prevailing security risks before accepting such assignments," the Ministry said



The Ministry of External Affairs has cited increasing attacks on ships in the region. FILE PHOTO

in its advisory, noting the security situation in the region and around the Black Sea and adjoining maritime areas. "Commercial vessels operating in or transiting these waters are facing significant security risks, including missile and drone attacks," it said.

The Ministry urged Indians to follow a set of precautions, such as obtaining "comprehensive information from employers/recruitment agencies and ship operators regarding the vessel's intended route, ports of call, security arrangements, and emergency response procedures". The "terms of employment" should "comply with applicable maritime standards and provide adequate provisions for medical care, evacuation, repatriation, and compensation in the event of an emergency," it said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10

EPS, former MLAs to appear before Speaker on July 30

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar has asked AIADMK general secretary and party floor leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami, and four former party MLAs who are facing disqualification proceedings under the provisions of the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution, to appear before him on July 30.

In a letter sent from the Assembly Secretariat to Mr. Palaniswami, Assembly Secretary R. Santhi said the Speaker had called four former AIADMK MLAs – Maragatham Kumaravel (Maduranthagam), P. Sathyabama (Dharapuram), S. Jeyakumar (Perundurai), and Esakki Subaya (Ambasamudram) – to appear before him individually between 11 a.m. and 12.30 p.m. on July 30, allotting each of them 30 minutes. The Speaker also asked Mr. Palaniswami to appear before him during the same time.

Disqualification petition
This was pursuant to a disqualification petition submitted by Mr. Palaniswami on May 13, after 25 rebel AIADMK MLAs voted in favour of the Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay-led Tamila



J.C.D. Prabhakar

ga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government during a vote of confidence in the Assembly. Later, Mr. Palaniswami condoned 21 of the 25 MLAs, while the four other members resigned from the Assembly and joined the TVK. During the inquiry into the petition, the four former MLAs appeared before the Speaker separately on two occasions, and gave explanations for their conduct during the trust vote in which they had "defied" the party whip. Thereafter, the Speaker sought clarifications from Mr. Palaniswami. On behalf of Mr. Palaniswami, AIADMK leaders recently submitted his explanation.

Against this backdrop, the Speaker asked both sides to appear before him, seeking further clarifications based on the explanations received from them earlier.

Tamil Nadu to host Southern Zonal Council meet in Aug.

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government is set to host the 31st Southern Zonal Council meeting in the third or fourth week of August at Mamallapuram, about 60 km south of Chennai.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah will chair the meeting. The State government has begun preparations to host the meeting. A few rounds of official coordination meetings have already been held, sources said.

Zonal Councils are statutory bodies established under the States Reorganisation Act, 1956. The Southern Zonal Council comprises Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Telangana, and the Union Territory of Puducherry.

The 31st Southern Zonal Council meeting was supposed to have been held at Mamallapuram in January 2025, but it was postponed.

Meanwhile, the Tamil Nadu government has nominated Ministers R. Nirmalkumar and Rajmohan as members of the Southern Zonal Council. They will serve as members, besides Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, representing Tamil Nadu.

Mirabai makes it a golden day for India; Rishikanta clinches a silver

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

Weightlifting has always been one of the disciplines that has contributed significantly to India's tally at the Commonwealth Games. The fact that the country has won as many as 33 medals in the last three editions underlines the vital role of the weightlifters.

On Sunday, the opening day of the weightlifting competition here, Indians once again made their presence felt by winning two medals – a gold and silver.

Hours after Rishikanta Singh Chanambam finished second in the men's 60kg category, Mirabai Chanu produced a golden moment in the women's 48kg class. For the latter, it was her third successive Commonwealth Games yellow metal after Gold Coast (2018) and Birmingham (2022).

Surprisingly, the 31-year-old had a shaky start to her snatch sequence, missing the opening attempt at 82kg. She, however, remained unflustered and returned to successfully lift the weight.

The lifter from Manipur went on to clear 85kg on her third visit, establish-



Manipuris' day out: It was triple delight for Mirabai while Rishikanta (below) became the first male lifter from the State to win a medal in the Commonwealth Games. PTI

ing a new Commonwealth Games record much to the delight of the Indian fans at the venue.



After failing to clear 105kg in her first clean and jerk attempt, Mirabai managed to overcome the challenge in her second try and finished with a total of 190kg, both new Games marks. Ruth Asuquo Nyong of Nigeria won silver with a total lift of 273kg while Irene Jane Henry of Malaysia clinched bronze with 167kg.

Growing tally

Earlier, Rishikanta won India's second medal at the Games with his silver. The 28-year-old began the snatch series with 116kg, increased it to 119kg and eventually

produced a 121kg lift. In clean and jerk, the Manipur lifter passed the 143kg test but failed in his next two attempts at 148kg and 151kg. Rishikanta finished with a combined lift of 264kg.

Malaysia's Mohamad Aniq Kasdan won the gold with a total lift of 273kg, setting a Games record. Kasdan also registered a new Games high in clean and jerk with 152kg.

Kenya's Joshua Amunga Mobye was the other podium finisher, thanks to his overall effort of 264kg (snatch: 121kg; clean and jerk: 143kg).

MORE REPORTS ON
» PAGE 15

Iran says it is halting 'retaliatory strikes' on U.S.

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Extending the weekend lull in fighting in West Asia, with the United States having halted operations after 13 days of strikes, Iran announced on Sunday that it too was halting its operations.

Iran's Army spokesperson Mohammad Akraminia was reported as saying: "Since our strategy has essentially been retaliatory, we have also halted our retaliatory operations."

On Sunday, Iran's Tasnim news agency claimed that a tanker exploded after it hit a mine while transiting the Strait of Hormuz through a route Tehran had not approved. The news agency had made a similar claim about another tanker on July 23, adding that two other tankers had refrained from crossing the Strait after that incident. While bodies that assess maritime threats, such as the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations, did not confirm these explosions, they have nevertheless warned of heightened risks from mines in the Strait.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
IRAN SLAMS UKRAINE ATTACK
» PAGE 14

INBRIEF



Adhesive gel pack found with food in Vande Bharat Express

Passengers in the Vande Bharat Express train proceeding from Mysuru to Chennai on Sunday found an adhesive gel packet along with the food served. D. Sekhar, a resident of Kathirvedu, said he was shocked to find the gel packet on the food tray. The passengers in the train reported the incident to the ticket examiner and gave a written complaint. He said this was a grave lapse on the part of the food contractor, and could have caused serious health hazards to the passengers. A senior official of Southern Railway said the incident had been reported to the IRC TC and the South Western Railway for further action.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (July 27, Monday), the following explainers are available:

- Why is China's AI push gaining ground? [newsth.live/chinaaipush](#)
- India's first dengue vaccine arrives with a crucial safety caveat [newsth.live/qdenga](#)

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Work on CMRL's Koyambedu-Alandur stretch hit by delays, to open next year

The Phase-II stretch from Koyambedu to Chennai Trade Centre was scheduled to be opened last month. While the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch awaits an inauguration date from the Centre, work on stations between Porur and Vadapalani has been held up and they will be ready in 3 months

TRACK TALES

Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

In what could be a let-down for commuters, Chennai Metro Rail's Phase II stretch from Koyambedu to Chennai Trade Centre, targeted for launch in June this year, has encountered nearly eight months of delay.

The Chennai Metro Rail will also complete the Alandur station, which comes after the Chennai Trade Centre, and may only open the Koyambedu-Alandur stretch by early next year.

It is to be noted that the first stretch of the Phase II project – Poonamallee to Vadapalani – has already missed its deadline and has still not been inaugurated.

CRS clearance

The Commissioner of Railway Safety (CRS) had cleared the opening of the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretch, with train stop-



Labour crunch: The Phase II stretch being built over the Kathipara Flyover. Officials say though the work was delayed mainly due to the shortage of workers, it has gathered pace now. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

page planned at all stations from Poonamallee to Porur. After Porur, the train will skip six stations and finally make a stop at Vadapalani. But the State government still awaits a date for the inauguration of this stretch from the Centre.

Meanwhile, the Chennai Metro Rail has delayed the

construction of the six stations between Porur and Vadapalani – Alapakkam, Karambakkam, Valasarakkum, Alwarthirunagar, Saligramam Warehouse, and Saligramam. They will be ready only after three months.

In the 118.9-km Phase II project, the Poonamallee-

Vadapalani stretch forms a part of corridor 4 (Poonamallee to Light House), and Koyambedu-Alandur comprises a section of corridor 5 (Madhavaram to Sholinganallur).

Difficult stretch

According to officials of the Chennai Metro Rail Limit-

Once the two stretches of the Phase II network are opened, commuters can switch to the Phase I network at Alandur, Vadapalani and Koyambedu

ed (CMRL), work on the Koyambedu-Alandur stretch was delayed primarily due to the shortage of workers, but now, it has gathered pace.

They said it was not easy to execute the work along this stretch, be it moving sewer lines or working amid limited permission at night.

'Viaduct completed'

"We have a good strength of workers and we are taking steps to expedite the construction. We have almost finished building the viaduct and have laid nearly 16 km of track," an official said.

The installation of the overhead equipment too, is under way. But one of

the most difficult works will be constructing the entry/exit structures of the stations from Koyambedu to Alandur.

Sources said that a significant part of the civil work was likely to be over by October-end.

"Only if the civil work is completed can the trial run begin on this stretch. Simultaneously, the work on signalling and telecommunication systems too will commence. This may go on for a minimum of 2-3 months. After that, the safety approvals have to be sought, inspections have to be carried out, and finally, the approval may be granted. There is quite a lot of work left to be done before the opening," another official said.

Once the Koyambedu-Alandur and the Poonamallee-Vadapalani stretches of the Phase II project are opened, Metro Rail commuters can change trains and switch to the Phase I network at Koyambedu, Vadapalani, and Alandur.

Students' federation organises rally seeking abolition of NEET and NTA

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Students Youth Federation (TSYF) organised a rally demanding the permanent scrapping of NEET, from Pudupet to the Rajarathinam stadium on Sunday.

A large number of people took part in the rally, seeking action against the police officials involved in assaulting the protesters at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, and the withdrawal of the FIRs filed against the students. They also demanded that the National Testing Agency (NTA) be wound up as it had failed to curb paper leaks.



Strong opposition: The Tamil Nadu Students Youth Federation takes out a rally demanding the abolition of NEET, at Egmore on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Disability rights activists to come up with plan for accessible bus stops

Meghna M.
CHENNAI

A wheelchair user tried getting on the electric low-floor bus with the ramp and the bus tilted down. With great might, he got on the first ramp, but the incline was too great for the next ramp, and he came rolling back to the bus stop.

Crutch users too found it difficult to use the ramp. The fault is not of the bus, but the bus stop. With no standard design, bus stop platforms vary in height, making it difficult to board low-floor buses, which are the most accessible for persons with disabilities. In an effort to standardise the design of future bus stops, the Disability Rights Alliance (DRA) started the 'Bus4all' initiative. Under this, nearly 10 ambulant persons with reduced mobility carried out accessibility audits at two bus stops on Kamarajar Salai on Sunday to formulate recommendations for an accessible bus stop.

"Five years ago, there were no low-floor buses. Now that we have electric low-floor buses, we also



A person with disability checking the accessibility at the bus stop near Vivekananda House on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

need accessible bus stops. This effort is to come up with the best accessible bus stops," said Satish Kumar, member of the DRA. At the model bus stop near Vivekananda House, the height of the bus stop was 300 mm. However, Gnana Bharathi, founder of Spinal Injured Persons Association, said that after alighting from the bus, he had to encounter immediate traffic as there was no access to the nearby footpath.

"The road and the footpath should be at the same level so that a person can climb easily. The footpath and the bus stop platform

also need to be aligned," he said.

The platform height continues to be a hindrance for persons with disabilities as, at some places, it is 300 mm, and 150 mm at others. DRA member Mee-nakshi Balasubramaniam added that the tactile tiles for the visually impaired did not have much space between them, leaving her with little space to use her crutches.

"Inside the bus itself, there is no place to hold our assistive devices, or we would have to leave them far from where we are seated, which is a problem.

With little leg room, there is no support for us to sit and not enough room for some of us to bend our legs," she added.

Mr. Bharathi also said many bus drivers did not stop the buses close to the bus stop. "They stop far away, defeating the purpose of low-floor buses. A curved path indicator would help drivers to stop at the bus stop and close enough for persons with disabilities to board easily," he added.

Pavithra Sriram, architect and co-founder of Design Co:Lab, added that the exercise helped understand how each user could access public infrastructure. "We are finding a way where everyone can walk in every space. This should ideally come from the city, and not advocacy groups. There are enough data, guidelines, and harmonised design guidelines, but implementation continues to lag," she said.

The DRA will submit their recommendations for accessible bus stops to the Greater Chennai Corporation and the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority.

'Stalin suppressed DMK Charitable Trust details in his election affidavit'

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

A writ petition has been filed in the Madras High Court for a direction to the Election Commission (EC) to inquire into a complaint about former Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin having allegedly suppressed certain details in his election affidavit, and consequently initiate criminal proceedings against him under Section 125A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951, if the allegations are substantiated.

The First Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan will hear on Monday the writ petition filed by 73-year-old advocate T. Sivagnanasambandan, who had contested against Mr. Stalin in Kolathur in the 2026 Assembly election as a candidate of the Desiya Makkal Sakthi Katchi.

The petitioner submitted that Section 33A of the 1951 Act, read with Rule 4A of the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961, requires every candidate contesting in the Lok Sabha and Assembly elections to file affidavits, along with Form-26, disclosing all of their movable and immovable assets, liabilities, beneficial interests, trusteeships, financial interests, and other material particulars.

Filing of the affidavit was not an empty formality, but a statutory requirement aimed at ensuring

transparency and integrity in the electoral process so that the electorate could make an informed choice after knowing about the financial status of the contestants, the petitioner said. He accused Mr. Stalin of not having disclosed details related to the DMK Charitable Trust.

The petitioner claimed that Mr. Stalin had become the managing trustee of the DMK Charitable Trust after the death of his father M. Karunanidhi in 2018. Thereafter, the trust had acquired an immovable property at Kadambadi village in Chengalpattu district for a valuable consideration of ₹2.27 crore, and the transaction was registered with the Tirukazhukundram Sub-Registrar's office in 2019.

However, this material particular had not been disclosed in the Form-26 affidavit filed before the Returning Officer, the petitioner alleged. He claimed to have made a representation in this regard to the EC as well as the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) on May 12, 2026.

Claiming that the EC and the CEO failed to act upon his representation, the petitioner sought a direction to them to consider and dispose of his plea "by conducting an inquiry into the allegations relating to suppression... and thereafter, take appropriate action in accordance with law if the allegations are found to be substantiated."

Timings CHENNAI			
MONDAY, JUL. 27			
RISE	05:54	SET	18:38
RISE	17:05	SET	03:41
TUESDAY, JUL. 28			
RISE	05:54	SET	18:37
RISE	17:52	SET	04:34
WEDNESDAY, JUL. 29			
RISE	05:54	SET	18:37
RISE	18:36	SET	05:27

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at **Narada Gana Sabha Mini Hall, Alwarpet**
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Today - July 27 - 5.45 pm :
KAVITHA MAANAS (Dis of T. M. Srividevi):
7.15pm **TEJASWINI SRIDHAR** (Dis of Janaki Ganesh)
Tomorrow 5.45 **SUGHI**
PARAARTHANA, 7.15 pm **K. JAHNAVI. ALL ARE WELCOME.**
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Chennai City	38	29

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37°C The weather will be very warm with an uneasy afternoon. The night also will be uneasy. There are chances of light rain and thundershowers.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
37°C The morning will be comfortable. The day will be very warm and uneasy. The night also will be uneasy. Rain and thundershowers likely.

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SCHEDULE B (WHOLE PROPERTY)
All that piece and parcel of land measuring 3220 Sq.ft. (299.15 Sq.mtr.) in Door No. 3, New Door No. 5, First Cross Street, Radhakrishna Nagar, Thiruvallur, Chennai - 600041, comprised in R.S. No. 132/1 of Thiruvallur Village, conveyed as below: **Item No. I** (Sale Deed Document No. 9798/2014 dated 10-09-2014); All that piece and parcel of 641 Sq.ft. or 59.55 Sq.mtr. undivided share of land out of 3220 Sq.ft. **Item No. II** (Sale Deed Document No. 9799/2014 dated 10-09-2014); All that piece and parcel of 865.23 Sq.ft. or 80.38 Sq.mtr. undivided share of land out of 3220 Sq.ft. **Item No. III** (Sale Deed Document No. 9800/2014 dated 10-09-2014); All that piece and parcel of 865.23 Sq.ft. or 80.38 Sq.mtr. undivided share of land out of 3220 Sq.ft. **Item No. IV** (Sale Deed Document No. 9801/2014 dated 10-09-2014); All that piece and parcel of 848.26 Sq.ft. or 78.80 Sq.mtr. undivided share of land out of 3220 Sq.ft., bounded on: North by Venkataraman's vacant site; South by 30 feet road; East by: Ramanathan's house; West by: Raghunathan's house.
SCHEDULE B
An RCC terraced building constructed thereon in Schedule A property within the Sub Registration District of Sadaipet and the Registration District of Chennai South.
Sd/- **M/s. S. Jagannathan, J. Kalidas, Advocates**, #5, 15th Cross St. Sastri Nagar, Adyar, Chennai-600020 Mob. 98411 82421
Counsel for intending purchaser
Place : Chennai; Date : 25-07-2026

Two arrested in TVK MLA poaching case move Madras High Court seeking bail

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Two arrested accused in the case relating to an alleged attempt to bribe ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) MLAs, have approached the Madras High Court seeking bail.

Earlier, the principal district and sessions court in Chennai had refused to grant them the relief on July 17, 2026 as the investigation was at a crucial stage and the huge Hawala transactions involved in the crime was yet to be unearthed fully.

Justice G.K. Ilanthirayan, holding the MP/MLA portfolio, would hear the bail petition filed by S. Karthik of Tiruppur and T. Ramesh of Karur on Monday (July 27) since former DMK Minister and sitting Coimbatore South MLA V. Senthilbalaji was one of the suspects who has been accused of offering a bribe of ₹35 crore for every TVK MLA besides a commission of ₹5 crore to middlemen who succeed in poaching them.

The petitioners, arrayed as the seventh and eighth accused in the case, had told the sessions court their names did not find place in the First Information Report (FIR) registered by the Triplicane police in Chennai on June 30 on the basis of a complaint lodged by Uthangarai TVK MLA N. Elaiyaraja. Yet, they were arrested solely on the basis of the investi-

gation conducted by the police.

Though the offences for which the petitioners had been booked would lead to a maximum punishment of seven years of imprisonment, the police had chosen to arrest them without calling them for inquiry by issuing notices under Section 35(3) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Surasksha Sanhita, they complained. They also accused the police of not having produced them before a judicial magistrate within 24 hours of their arrest.

Further, alleging the police had threatened and compelled them to give a confession implicating Mr. Senthilbalaji and his brother R.V. Ashok Kumar in the case, the petitioners said, the brothers were mere acquaintances with whom they had no monetary, business, political or any other transaction. Since custodial interrogation had also taken place in the case, they urged the court to enlarge them on bail.

On the other hand, the prosecution told the court the petitioners had participated actively in the planning and execution of the conspiracy to destabilise the government and they played a vital role in facilitating the illegal activities. They had participated in various meetings held at different hotels in Chennai and exchanged scanned copies of ₹100 and ₹20 notes to be used for Hawala transactions.

GCC set to launch Intelligent Transport System in August

The project aims to enhance traffic management, improve road safety, and provide better public transport services; it is being implemented at a cost of ₹530 cr., with financial assistance from JICA

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) will launch the Intelligent Transport System (ITS) in the city in August.

GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran said the project was a major step towards realising a safer, commuter-friendly city.

The project, being implemented with financial assistance from the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA), is making significant progress towards transforming urban mobility across the Chennai Metropolitan Area. The project, estimated at ₹530 crore, aims to enhance traffic management, improve road safety, and provide better public transport services through the adoption of advanced intelligent transportation technologies, said an official.

The project comprises two components, the Traffic Information and Management System (TIMS) for the Greater Chennai Traffic Police (GCTP) and the City Bus System (CBS) for the Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC).

Traffic signal

Under TIMS, advanced systems such as Adaptive Traffic Signal Control Systems, Traffic Incident Detection Systems, Variable Message Sign Boards, Red Light Violation Detection Systems, Speed Limit Violation De-



For smooth commute: The project comprises two components, the Traffic Information and Management System and the City Bus System, which will improve traffic flow and public transportation.

tection Systems, and Automatic Traffic Counter and Classifier Systems are being installed at strategic locations across the city, an official said.

These systems will facilitate real-time traffic monitoring, automated enforcement, and data-driven traffic management, resulting in smoother traffic flow and improved road safety. Significant progress has already been achieved under the Adaptive Traffic Signal Control System (ATCS), with installations completed at 101 junctions and successfully integrated with the temporary Traffic Control Centre of the GCTP. Installation and integration works are under way at the other locations, the official said.

The Red-Light Violation Detection System (RLVD) has been implemented at 25 locations, incorporating automated number plate recognition and challan

generation to improve compliance with traffic regulations.

Speed limit detector

The Speed Limit Violation Detection System (SLVD) has been installed at three locations to monitor over-speeding vehicles and strengthen road safety enforcement. "We will install the system at seven locations shortly," said an official.

Traffic Incident Detection Systems (TIDS) have been installed at 47 strategic flyover locations to facilitate real-time traffic monitoring, incident detection, and quicker emergency response. In addition, Variable Message Sign Boards (VMS) have been installed at three locations to provide commuters with real-time traffic updates, incident alerts, and alternative route information, said the official.

A modern Traffic Infor-

mation and Management Centre (TIMC) is also being established at the GCTP Headquarters. The facility will serve as the city's centralised traffic monitoring and control hub and is expected to be completed by the end of August 2026.

The CBS component includes the deployment of Automatic Vehicle Location Systems in 3,500 MTC buses, Passenger Information Systems at 616 bus stops and depots, and Depot Management Systems across 32 depots. These initiatives will enable real-time bus tracking, accurate arrival information for commuters, and improved efficiency in bus operations.

Implementation activities are progressing steadily across the city. Necessary permissions for communication network infrastructure have been facilitated by the Greater Chennai Corporation and the State Highways Department.

For locations where installation of equipment has been found technically infeasible, suitable alternate locations have been identified to ensure optimal project coverage and effective utilisation of the systems, said the official.

Power connections are being secured at project locations, while minor junction improvement works are also being carried out to support the deployment of intelligent traffic management infrastructure.

History-sheeters hurl Molotov cocktail at a house in Mogappair

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A Molotov cocktail attack on a house in Mogappair created tension among the residents, and the Nolambur police have filed a case to nab the offenders.

A senior official of the city police said Anand was a resident of Mogappair Block 2 and had acquaintance with history-sheeters Jai Ganesh and Chota Ram.

Heated argument

On Saturday night, Anand and the history-sheeters consumed alcohol, during which a heated argument broke out between them.

Anand left the place and came home to sleep. Suddenly, a gang of men came to Anand's house and

A search is on to nab the history-sheeters Jai Ganesh and Chota Ram, and their accomplices

threw a Molotov cocktail. Anand's elder brother, Arun, tried to stop the gang from entering the house and was attacked with a sickle. He sustained a head injury in the attack.

Arun was immediately rushed to a private hospital and is undergoing treatment.

The Nolambur police are conducting a search to apprehend the persons involved in the attack, including Jai Ganesh and Chota Ram, and their accomplices.

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Experts stress need for early diagnosis, identifying underlying cause of anaemia

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

"Anaemia is not a disease by itself but a clinical finding that signals an underlying health condition. Identifying its cause is the first step towards effective treatment," experts said during *The Hindu's* webinar titled 'Anaemia: Understanding Causes and Effects' on Sunday.

Many causes

The experts explained that while iron deficiency remains the most common cause of anaemia, the condition can also result from deficiencies of Vitamin B12 or folate, inherited blood disorders such as thalassemia and sickle cell disease, chronic kidney disease, infections, autoimmune disorders, bone marrow diseases, and several other underlying illnesses.

They stressed that management should always be tailored to the underlying cause, rather than assuming all anaemia is due to iron deficiency.



Experts also cautioned against self-medication with iron supplements without medical evaluation. GETTY IMAGES

Ramya Uppuluri, consultant paediatric haematologist and oncologist, Apollo Hospitals, discussed anaemia in children and adolescents, explaining its nutritional and inherited causes, early warning signs and the importance of timely diagnosis during the growing years.

She also highlighted the role of adequate nutrition, early intervention and regular follow-up in preventing complications that could affect growth, deve-

They say while iron deficiency remains the most common cause of anaemia, it can also be caused by Vitamin B12 or folate deficiency, or inherited blood disorders

lopment and learning.

Speaking on anaemia in adults, Divya M., consultant haematologist, Rela Hospital, outlined the investigations used to determine the underlying cause of anaemia and discussed advances in diagnosis and treatment.

She explained that treatment should be guided by the cause of anaemia rather than relying solely on iron supplements, and highlighted newer diagnostic approaches and management options for complex blood disorders.

Recognising symptoms

Subham Bhattacharya, consultant, haematology, CK Birla Hospitals discussed advances in diag-

nosing and managing anaemia, and emphasised the importance of recognising symptoms early and seeking appropriate medical care

During the question-and-answer session, participants raised queries on iron deficiency without anaemia, persistent anaemia despite iron therapy, inherited blood disorders, the impact of anaemia on cognition and immunity, blood donation and iron stores, newer laboratory tests, and the need to strengthen public health screening beyond haemoglobin estimation.

The experts highlighted that balanced nutrition, routine health screening, early diagnosis, and evidence-based treatment are essential to reducing the burden of anaemia and preventing long-term complications.

The session was moderated by Athira Elssa Johnson, Senior Reporter, *The Hindu*.

The webinar can be viewed at <https://newsth.live/anaemia>

Security guard found dead inside MEPZ with face injury; police rule out foul play

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A security guard was found dead at the Madras Export Processing Zone (MEPZ) in the early hours of Sunday.

A senior official of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate said Muniyan, a resident of Nehru Nagar in Kadapperi near Tambaram was working as a security guard in a private pharma-

A senior police official said the guard fell down as he was heavily drunk, leading to his death

ceutical company located in the Tambaram MEPZ complex, for the past eight months.

On Saturday night, he

had reported for duty but did not return home. Based on the alert from his relative, the Tambaram police launched a search. A police team found him dead, lying in a pool of blood with a severe injury to the left side of his face, near the company premises.

A senior official of the Tambaram Police Commissionerate said inquiries

and CCTV footage revealed that there was no foul play in the death of the security guard.

He was heavily drunk and had fallen down and died, the official said.

Tambaram Police Inspector Chelladurai, after inspecting the crime scene, sent the body to the Tambaram Government hospital for a post-mortem examination.

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Presents

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V. Manickavasagam
K. Alamelu

India's doctoral research ecosystem in Social Sciences is in urgent need of a structural overhaul. While doctoral scholars in other countries are evaluated on working prototypes and real-world applications, the Indian system remains wedded to voluminous dissertations and the pressure to publish in so-called peer-reviewed or indexed journals.

Problems
The mandatory publication requirement has lowered the quality of research and spawned an entire ecosystem of predatory and cloned journals that exploit desperate doctoral candidates who pay hefty sums to get their papers published. The publishing landscape has undergone a damaging inversion: where journals once paid scholars for their contributions, today scholars pay for the privilege of being published. Even more troubling is the exploitation by supervisors, ranging from demands to ghostwrite papers under the supervisor's name to performing domestic errands and, in extreme cases, being asked to pay to complete research within stipulated deadlines. Universities themselves are not free of blame. Administrative delays plague doctoral candidates from the mo-

A missing link

Why Social Sciences research must connect to societal and real-world issues

ment of registration up to thesis adjudication and result publication. In one reported incident, a Teacher Association had to intervene just to clear procedural formalities and resolve the reasons behind a delay. The contrast with the Sciences is stark. Doctoral students collaborate on lab experiments, co-develop working protocols, create patentable products, and contribute to joint intellectual property. Social

Science scholars, meanwhile, work in relative isolation on topics chosen less for societal relevance than for administrative compliance, completing research that is rarely tested against real-world rigour.

Revamp needed
A resurgence in the research environment in Social Science requires regu-

latory bodies to ensure that universities are linked with the society around them. A mandatory academia-industry link for research and adoption of higher education institutes by industries can lead to research projects that address the problems that these companies face.

The departments of Pedagogy, Adult Education,

and Lifelong Learning can be directed to focus on issues such as curriculum design challenges, the integration of Artificial Intelligence in teaching and learning, and the development of scientific student assessment tools. By maintaining direct links with government departments and organisations working with child welfare, the Departments of Special Education and Rehabilitation can look at early identification of differently-abled children and their integration into mainstream life.

The Economics Department can work with district, state, and national planning bodies to prepare annual plans meant for optimal allocation of government resources. Data collection through field research and the analy-

sis involved are routine aspects of research. Grassroots issues like farmer distress or problems of informal workers can be an area of collaborative research with Labour Commissions, State Finance Commissions and so on. So far, only a handful of institutions such as Gokhale Research Institute and the Madras Institute of Development Studies have made a mark in the national planning bodies. Creating a link with governmental organs can help Economics departments transform shelf-bound research into a mutually beneficial societal endeavour. Departments of Sociology, Social Work, Psychology and Philosophy can establish links to local bodies, prisons, juvenile homes and NGOs working in rehabilitation and child protection to address and find solutions to social problems.

The doctoral theses that result from India's current research system often lie in archives; unread, unapplied, and of no use to the stakeholders in whose name they were ostensibly written. This is a systemic failure of purpose. The missing link between academia and society must be not only established but made mandatory in every university. Only then will India's doctoral degrees reflect the rigour and relevance that the nation's investment in higher education demands.

Views expressed are personal

V. Manickavasagam is Advisor, IQAC, and K. Alamelu is Director- IQAC and Senior Professor at the Department of Banking Management, Alagappa University.

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Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

IELTS update

IDP Education has announced that IELTS in India will transition from IELTS on Paper to IELTS on Computer from September 2026. The IELTS on Paper will be available in India until August end.

From September 2026 onwards, candidates in India will be able to choose from two options. IELTS on Computer will have the Listening, Reading

and Writing sections on a computer. IELTS on Computer (Writing on Paper) allows test takers to complete the Listening and Reading sections on a computer, while completing the Writing section on paper.

The Speaking test will continue to be conducted face-to-face with a certified IELTS examiner for both modes. For more information on the changes, visit ieltsidpindia.com/

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INBRIEF



7th State Finance Commission's tenure extended till Dec. 31

The Tamil Nadu government has extended the tenure of the Seventh State Finance Commission by four months, until December 31 this year. Its tenure was to have expired on August 31. The Commission, chaired by retired IAS officer K. Allaudin, was constituted in May 2025 to study the financial position of village panchayats, panchayat union councils, district panchayats, town panchayats, municipalities, and municipal corporations, and make recommendations on the distribution of funds to be provided by the government. The Commission was to have submitted its report by August 31, covering the five-year period commencing from April 1, 2027.

MMK flays Centre for rejecting Metro Rail projects for T.N.

The Manithaneya Makkal Katchi (MMK) on Sunday condemned the Union government for rejecting the Tamil Nadu government's proposals for Metro Rail projects in Coimbatore and Madurai for a second time recently. In a statement, P. Abdul Samad, the party's general secretary, said the Centre's rejection of the Tamil Nadu government's proposal was a deliberate attempt to stall the growth of the State. He alleged that the move was against the spirit of cooperative federalism. Mr. Samad also questioned the Union government's rationale in not applying the same population criterion while granting approval for Metro Rail projects in other States.

Two workers killed in explosion at illegal fireworks unit in Sivakasi

One worker, who suffered 75% burns, is in a critical condition at the government hospital in Virudhunagar. The police say the owners had set up the fireworks unit without licence and used the free electricity meant for agriculture to run it

S. Sundar
SIVAKASI

Two workers were killed and another suffered 75% burns in an explosion at an illegal fireworks unit functioning out of a shed near Sengamalapatti in Sivakasi on Sunday. A search is under way for two persons, who, according to their relatives, also worked at the unit.

The police identified one of the deceased as R. Ramprakash, 36, of Sengamalapatti. The other victim is yet to be identified. The injured person was identified as R. Ramachandran, 38, Ramprakash's elder brother. He has been admitted to the Virudhunagar Government Medical College hospital and is in a critical condition. Tamil Nadu Fire and Rescue Services personnel from Sivakasi, led by Station Officer T. Seenivasan, rushed to the spot and brought the fire under control after a lengthy operation.

A van that was parked near the shed was gutted, while a two-wheeler was partially burnt in the blaze.

White fumes could be seen several kilometres from the shed after a loud blast was heard around



Fatal blast: Personnel of the Tamil Nadu Fire and Rescue Services spraying water at the site of the explosion near Sengamalapatti in Sivakasi on Sunday. G. MOORTHY

8.30 a.m. Parts of the van were found some 20 metres from the site of the explosion. While one worker was completely charred inside the shed, the other was blown to pieces, according to the firemen. The window panes of two houses in the vicinity of the shed were shattered during the explosion.

Neighbours claimed that they had been unaware that an illegal fireworks manufacturing unit was operating in the area.

"We have seen those in the shed running a nursery and also water being fetched by vans from a nearby irrigation well. We never suspected that they had been making firecrackers illegally," said Muthulakshmi, a 51-year-old resident of the locality.

Virudhunagar MLA P. Selvam rushed to the spot and oversaw and rescue operations. He said the Sivakasi East police had uncovered 10 similar illegal fireworks manufacturing

units in the last few weeks. "With Deepavali only a few months away, I have asked Gautam Goyal, Virudhunagar Superintendent of Police, to intensify checks at fireworks industry to prevent such accidents," Mr. Selvam said.

Meanwhile, the police said Ramprakash and Ramachandran, who owned the farmland and the irrigation well, had set up the fireworks manufacturing unit stealthily. "The workers had start-

ed operations around 3 a.m. They had used the free electricity meant for agriculture to power the shed," the police officer said.

As some people complained that their relatives, who were employed at the unit, were missing, the firemen used a drone to search nearby areas, including farmlands, in an effort to locate them. Besides, efforts were under way to pump water from a nearby well to check whether the missing workers could have been thrown into it by the blast. The Sivakasi East police have begun an investigation.

Fire at Pernaickenpatti Meanwhile, a fire broke out at a licensed fireworks unit at Pernaickenpatti near Sivakasi. This was reported within an hour of the explosion at the other unit. However, being a Sunday, no workers were at the Jai Vinayaka Sparklers unit where the fire broke out.

The blaze destroyed boxes and other packing materials. It was put out by firemen from the Sivakasi fire station. A short circuit is suspected to have caused the fire.

Governor, party leaders observe Kargil Vijay Diwas

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

On the occasion of Kargil Vijay Diwas, Tamil Nadu Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar, BJP State unit president Nainar Nagenthiran, and We The Leaders founder K. Annamalai paid tributes to soldiers of the Indian Armed Forces.

In a post on X, the Lok Bhavan, quoting Mr. Arlekar, said: "On the solemn occasion of Kargil Vijay Diwas, I pay my heartfelt tributes to the valiant soldiers of the Indian Armed Forces whose unparalleled courage, unwavering determination, and supreme sacrifice secured our nation's victory in the Kargil War. Let us reaffirm our gratitude to our Armed Forces and resolve to uphold the ideals of patriotism, unity, and national service. Jai Hind!"

In a social media post, Mr. Nagenthiran lauded the contributions of the Armed Forces.

The nation would remain indebted to them for their sacrifices, the BJP leader said.

Mr. Annamalai, in a social media post, said that on this day, he remembered the courage, grit and selflessness of the soldiers who fought under impossible circumstances.

‘Stalin’s allegation of CM’s inaction on Mekedatu issue contrary to facts’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Minister for Public Works and Sports Development Aadhav Arjuna said on Sunday that DMK president M.K. Stalin's allegations that Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay had not taken any measure to secure the State's share of Cauvery water and oppose Karnataka's proposal to build a balancing reservoir across the Cauvery at Mekedatu were "contrary to facts".

In a statement, Mr. Arjuna said the State government was committed to protecting the livelihood of farmers in the Cauvery delta, ensuring the State's drinking water security, and safeguarding its legal right to Cauvery water.

Recalling Mr. Vijay's meeting with Prime Minis-



Aadhav Arjuna

ter Narendra Modi in New Delhi on May 27, the Minister said Mr. Vijay had submitted a memorandum explaining Tamil Nadu's stand on the Cauvery water sharing issue, and the Mekedatu project and its likely impact on delta farmers.

He also recalled the let-

ter written by Mr. Vijay to Mr. Modi, elaborating on various aspects of the final award of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal and the Supreme Court's judgment on Cauvery water sharing, objecting to the Mekedatu project, and the resolution unanimously adopted by the Tamil Nadu Assembly against the Mekedatu project.

He said the Tamil Nadu government had consistently been pursuing all legal, administrative, and political measures to safeguard the State's rights to Cauvery water.

Referring to the previous DMK government, Mr. Arjuna said the Supreme Court had dismissed Tamil Nadu's petition against Karnataka's Detailed Project Report for the Mekedatu dam on No-

vember 13, 2025. A review petition filed by the then government was dismissed on April 15, 2026, followed by the dismissal of a curative petition on April 25. He alleged that the previous government had failed to effectively present Tamil Nadu's case and those legal setbacks had contributed to the present situation.

"We [the State government] do not wish to divert our focus from the Cauvery water dispute and the Mekedatu dam issue by dwelling on such lapses of the past. We have no such narrow political motive. At the same time, we are always open to considering, examining, and accepting constructive criticism, not only from former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin but also from anyone," the Minister added.

Over 28,000 get allotment orders in first round of TNEA counselling

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu Engineering Admissions (TNEA) has given allotment orders to 28,550 candidates under Round 1 of counselling.

Under this, 8,811 tentative allotment orders were given and 19,739 received provisional allotment orders.

In the academic category, 8,016 tentative allotment orders were given and 17,034 candidates received provisional allotments.

Further, under the 7.5% reservation for government students, 560 tentative allotment orders and 1,683 provisional allotment orders were also handed out.

In the vocational category, 175 tentative allotment



Time limit: Officials say if the seats are not claimed by July 30, the allotments will be cancelled. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

orders were given and 886 provisional allotments were made.

Under the 7.5% reservation for government students in this category, 60 tentative allotments and 136 provisional allotments were made.

According to a press re-

lease from the TNEA, the students who received their tentative allotment order should go to the TNEA Facilitation Centers (TFCs), as mentioned in their options, and submit their original certificates. They also need to pay the tuition fee as given in the

In the vocational category, 175 tentative allotment orders were given and 886 provisional allotments were made

allotment order to confirm the currently allocated seat and enable upward movement on or before July 30. Those who received provisional allotment must report to the college and complete the admission process by July 30 as well.

The officials added that if the seats were not claimed within the deadline, the allotments would be cancelled.

These seats would then be allotted to students on the waiting in the same round.

PMK releases ‘Shadow Economic Survey’ for second year in a row

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Ahead of its Shadow Budget presentation on Monday, the Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) on Sunday unveiled its 'Shadow Economic Survey' for the second consecutive year.

According to the report, against the projected State's Own Tax Revenue (SOTR) of ₹2,20,895 crore, only ₹1,92,493.07 crore was mobilised, recording a shortfall of 13%. None of the major components of the SOTR, including the Goods and Services Tax (GST), stamp duty and registration charges, and motor vehicle tax, met their targets.

Although Tamil Nadu's economy grew by 10.83% in 2024-25, the report said the higher growth did not translate into higher revenue for the exchequer. The

State's non-tax revenue for 2025-26 was 29.10%, lower than the previous year and 17.31% below the Budget estimate, the report said. The State also received a lower-than-expected share of Central taxes and grants-in-aid, it said.

Capital expenditure

Capital expenditure did not increase in 2025-26, resulting in limited creation of public infrastructure and productive assets.

At the same time, revenue expenditure rose sharply. The government's failure to increase revenue and contain expenditure significantly widened the revenue deficit, the report said.

The ₹6,000-crore farm loan waiver, the enhancement of free electricity to 200 units, and the closure of 717 Tasmac outlets would further widen the

revenue deficit in 2026-27, it said.

With the State's total debt projected to reach ₹16.70 lakh crore by the end of the current year, the government would have to pay ₹80,000 crore as interest on its borrowings in 2026-27. Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs) would have to pay around ₹48,875 crore as interest on their borrowings, the report said.

To augment revenue, the report suggested measures to increase the SOTR to 7% over the next five years and raise the State's economic growth to 12%-13% annually. It also said the Centre's shareable tax pool allocated to the States should be increased to 50%, and that cesses and surcharges levied by the Union government should be merged with the divisible pool of taxes.

Tasmac bars can now be operated within 100 m of liquor shops

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government has amended the liquor vending rules to allow Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (Tasmac) bars to be set up within a 100-metre radius of liquor outlets, replacing the existing requirement that they be attached to retail shops.

The State government has issued a Government Order (G.O.) pertaining to this. Sources said the move was aimed at widening participation in the tender process and breaking the monopoly of a few operators who have dominated bar contracts for years. The minimum area requirement for a bar has also been increased from 15 sq.m to 20 sq.m (about 215 sq.ft).

Tasmac bars have always been small establishments that are often poorly maintained.

‘Space still inadequate’ People working at these bars, whom *The Hindu* spoke to, said the increase in the minimum area requirement was still inadequate. "If there is an emergency, there won't be enough space for people to evacuate safely. The government should consider increasing the minimum space further," they said.

Tasmac is a major revenue generator for the State government.

The corporation operates 4,048 retail liquor outlets across the State, and generates around ₹150 crore from liquor sales every day through its retail network.

Govt. to introduce AI software to expedite building plan approval

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government is in the process of developing a software powered by advanced technologies and artificial intelligence (AI) to expedite the building plan approval process, particularly in urban areas.

According to sources, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay has directed officials to ensure building plan approvals are processed without delay wherever applications comply with the prescribed requirements. Accordingly, the government has been developing a new software by leveraging artificial intelligence and other advanced technologies. The new system is expected to process applications more efficiently and reduce the time taken for granting



Quick clearance: The new system is expected to process applications more efficiently. GETTY IMAGES

building plan approvals.

Further, measures are being taken to expedite the constitution of urban development authorities in Hosur, Salem, Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Tiruchi and Madurai, sources said.

The State government had notified urban development authorities for these cities in 2021, but they are yet to be formally constituted and made functional on the lines of the Chennai Metropolitan

Development Authority (CMDA).

Facelift for tenements

Following complaints about the poor condition of old tenements constructed by the Tamil Nadu Urban Habitat Development Board, the State government is also taking measures to renovate and reconstruct around 28,000 dilapidated houses across the State, sources added.

INBRIEF



TDP's people's outreach to focus on NDA's success

The TDP is set to launch a 45-day door-to-door campaign on Monday on the achievements of the coalition government in the last two years. Addressing party leaders and public representatives on the eve of the campaign through a teleconference on Sunday, TDP national president and Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu said the two years of governance and crucial issues must be highlighted.

Andhra Pradesh govt. unveils AI platform to forecast floods

The Andhra Pradesh government has launched City Flood Alert, an AI-powered technology platform developed by the Real Time Governance Society (RTGS) with the Andhra Pradesh State Disaster Management Authority (APSDMA) and IIT-Gandhinagar. The platform is designed to predict urban flooding before it occurs, enabling authorities to take preventive measures well in advance. The platform will initially be deployed in Vijayawada.

Vemulawada temple set to receive additional ₹99.4 cr.

The ongoing expansion and development work at the Sri Raja Rajeshwara Swamy temple in Vemulawada of Rajanna Sircilla district in Telangana is set to receive an additional ₹99.40 crore. According to temple sources, the government had earlier allocated ₹50 crore in the 2023-24 Budget and ₹100 crore in the 2024-25 Budget for the temple development works. The development works, taken up at an estimated cost of ₹150 crore, are progressing.

Siddaramaiah calls time on career in electoral politics

Former Karnataka CM says he will not contest the 2028 Assembly election but will continue to serve people and the party; the year marks 50 years of his political career, Congress leader says

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

Former Karnataka Chief Minister Siddaramaiah has announced his retirement from electoral politics, while asserting that he will continue to remain active in public life and work for the Congress and the people.

Addressing a gathering during the 86th birth anniversary celebrations of former Speaker, the late ‘K.R. Pet’ Krishna, at K.R. Pet town in Mandya district on Saturday, the veteran Congress leader said he would not contest the 2028 Assembly election.



Turned down: Siddaramaiah declined party's offer of Rajya Sabha seat, saying he is not interested in national politics. ANI

However, would remain active in politics.

The announcement came after supporters urged him to remain in electoral politics for another decade.

He had also declined the

party's reported offer of a Rajya Sabha seat, saying he was not interested in national politics.

‘Polluted politics’ Later, in a Facebook post on Sunday, Mr. Siddara-

maiah said the changing nature of politics had influenced his decision.

“Politics has become polluted. Therefore, I have decided not to contest the 2028 Assembly election. However, I will remain active in politics, stay with the people and continue to support them,” he said.

Recalling his political journey, Mr. Siddaramaiah said he entered public life in 1978 as a member of the Taluk Board and would complete 50 years in politics in 2028.

“I have witnessed victory and defeat, but I have never compromised on my ideology or betrayed my conscience,” he said.

Revanth to speak to Rahul over opening doors of Parliament, Assembly to Gen Z

R. Ravikanth Reddy
HYDERABAD

Proposing a new slogan – “Jai Jawan, Jai Kisan and Jai Yuva” – Telangana Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy has said that the country should be ready to channel the energies of the Gen Z (demographic group born roughly between 1997 to 2012) and give them more political opportunities.

He will take the first step towards this by proposing to Congress leader Rahul

Gandhi a reduction of the age for entry into the Legislature to 21, Mr. Reddy said in an informal chat with the media here on Sunday.

He said that the issue would be discussed with Mr. Gandhi and AICC president Mallikarjun Kharge during his visit to New Delhi on Monday.

Mr. Gandhi would be requested to discuss this with the INDIA bloc partners and other parties, the Chief Minister said.

The Telangana govern-

ment would pass a resolution in the Assembly in August this year, he said, adding that in Parliament, the Opposition could explore the opportunity to introduce it as a Private Members’ Bill to put pressure on the ruling party.

Mr. Reddy further said that several seniors in his party were in tune with his idea of passing a resolution in the State Assembly in August.

“We will send the resolution to the Centre so that

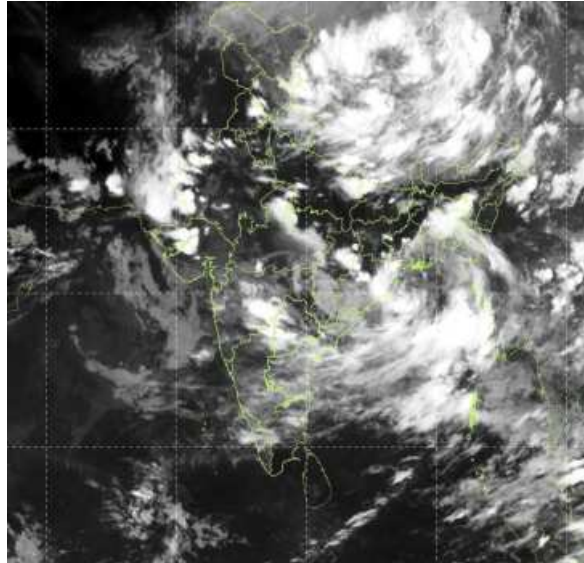
the proposal could be discussed along with the proposed Delimitation Bill, Women’s Reservation Bill and the enhancement of Lok Sabha seats.”

“If needed, the proposal could also be referred to a Joint Parliamentary Committee for consultations,” he said.

“Mr. Modi can no longer depend on one-way communication like with his ‘Mann ki Baat’ on radio. He also has to listen to the country’s voice.”

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall with isolated extremely heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Chhattisgarh and Odisha. Thundersquall with wind speed reaching (50-60kmph) very likely at isolated places over coastal Andhra Pradesh and Odisha.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		35.8	26.8	Kurnool		35.4	25.8
Ahmedabad	14.5	29.3	24.2	Lucknow		36.7	28.0
Aizawl	0.6	33.0	24.1	Madurai		41.1	27.0
Bengaluru		28.4	21.3	Mangaluru	65.6	29.1	23.8
Bhopal			23.0	Mumbai			
Bhubaneswar	77.9	30.7	24.4	Mysuru		30.8	19.8
Chandigarh			28.0	New Delhi		35.7	27.1
Chennai		38.0	29.1	Patna		36.7	28.1
Coimbatore		32.4	22.6	Port Blair		2.0	31.2
Dehradun				Prayagraj		4.2	37.5
Gangtok	0.5	24.5	18.5	Puducherry			38.7
Gorakhpur		9.6	32.0	Pune		6.0	27.5
Guwahati	0.2	34.9	27.4	Raipur			23.9
Hubballi			28.0	Ranchi		30.8	23.0
Hyderabad		32.3	24.2	Shillong			
Imphal		31.7	25.8	Shimla		13.9	22.8
Jaipur		26.7		Srinagar		12.8	27.8
Kochi		30.6	25.6	Thiruvananthapuram		33.7	25.4
Kohima		8		Tiruchirappalli		39.1	28.0
Kolkata		9.6	32.4	Vijayawada		34.5	29.0
Kozhikode		9.7	34.0	Visakhapatnam		34.5	29.0

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	In observation made at
Ahmedabad	56	60	96	85	124		4.00 p.m., Raebareilly, Uttar Pradesh recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 500
Bengaluru		4	7		23	70	indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Pamore, Jammu and Kashmir recorded a healthy AQI score of 10.
Chennai		4	5	33	15	180	
Delhi		13	25	39	137	128	
Hyderabad			2	14	24	45	
Kolkata			16	19	57	68	
Lucknow				8	23	52	
Mumbai				5	6	33	
Pune				18	63	25	
Visakhapatnam				34	64	9	

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness, and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

One killed, 20 injured as bus overturns in Kerala

The Hindu Bureau
MALAPPURAM

One passenger was killed and 20 were injured, three seriously, after a private bus overturned on National Highway no. 66 at Kuttippuram in Malappuram district of Kerala around 11 a.m. on Sunday.

The bus was on its way from Kozhikode to Thrissur when the driver reportedly lost control of the vehicle.

According to local people, the bus first struck a road divider on the right before yawing to the left. As it rotated, its right side swung forward and slammed into a roadside retaining wall. The force of the impact overturned the bus and split it into two.

The bus came to rest on top of a car parked on the service road. The car had remained there after it was damaged in an accident at

the same spot a few days earlier.

The deceased was identified as Vaishnav, a native of Peruvayal in Kozhikode district. He was reportedly travelling to Thrissur with his brother to attend a Public Service Commission (PSC) examination.

The injured were admitted to hospitals at Kottakkal, Valanchery, and Kuttippuram.

The police and the Motor Vehicles department have launched an investigation.

Surveillance video footage shows the bus veering left towards a service road opening, swinging around and slamming its right side into the retaining wall before overturning.

Local people said several accidents had occurred at the same spot in recent months. They alleged design flaws in the highway for the latest crash.



The wreckage of the bus being removed from the highway at Kuttippuram in Malappuram district of Kerala on Sunday. ANI

A.P. govt. promises to resolve Bhogapuram airport land issues

K. Srinivasa Rao
VIZIANAGARAM

Andhra Pradesh Minister for MSME and NRI Affairs Kondapalli Srinivas and other senior officials have assured farmers that the government will address the pending issues of those who surrendered their land for the Greenfield International Airport at Bhogapuram in Vizianagaram district.

The assurance comes ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's scheduled visit to the airport on August 1. While compensation and the rehabilitation

and resettlement (R&R) package have been settled in most cases, a section of the affected farmers is yet to receive the benefits.

The government had initially offered compensation of ₹48 lakh an acre for land acquired for the approach road connecting National Highway-16 with the airport. However, some farmers demanded up to ₹1 crore an acre, citing prevailing market rates.

The government is learnt to have deposited the amount with the tribunal in Visakhapatnam, asking farmers to claim it through the court process.

Kerala Forest Dept. maps elephants straying into human habitats, fields

C.P. Sajit
KANNUR

The Forest department in Kerala has begun profiling individual elephants that repeatedly stray into human settlements, in an effort to better understand their movement patterns and improve conflict mitigation in north Kerala.

Speaking to The Hindu, Chief Conservator of Forests (Northern Circle) B.N. Anjankumar said the decision to monitor and profile wild animals, particularly elephants, was taken in view of the growing incidents of human-wildlife conflict, especially in Ara-



The decision to monitor and profile wild animals was taken in view of the growing incidents of human-wildlife conflict. FILE PHOTO

lam farm, Kannur, and areas adjoining the forest fringes.

He said Rapid Response Teams, field staff, and forest watchers are documenting habitual straying

elephants through photographs, videos, and field reports after officials observed that some animals follow predictable behavioural patterns, including entering human settle-

ments, particularly when human activity is at its lowest, feeding in agricultural areas, and returning to the forest before daybreak.

Need scientific study

Mr. Anjankumar further pointed out that wild animal intrusions into human settlements, especially in Aralam, Kottiyoor, and other forest fringes, consistently peak during the early monsoon months of July and August. He backed the claim by stating that the trend is based on incident data collected over several years, though the exact reasons require detailed scientific study.

Sitting MLAs among Kerala leaders facing sexual abuse charges

Deborah Thambi
KOCHI

Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leader and former legislator M.C. Kamaruddin, who has around 120 cases pending against him, tops the list of people's representatives facing criminal proceedings in Kerala.

Mr. Kamaruddin was one of the accused in the Fashion Gold Jewellery investment fraud of 2019. He was booked by invoking the provisions of the Banning of Unregulated Deposit Schemes (BUDS) Act, 2019. Five people's repre-

sentatives – Kovalam MLA M. Vincent, former Kazhakkuttam MLA M.A. Vaheed, Thrissur MP Suresh Gopi, former Parassala MLA A.T. George, and Kunnathunadu MLA V.P. Sajeendran – are reportedly facing sexual harassment charges.

Former Koothuparamba MLA P. Jayarajan and former Kalliasery MLA T.V. Rajesh have murder charges pending against them.

The details of the pending cases against sitting or former MPs and MLAs emerged following a recent report submitted by the District Judiciary before the Kerala High Court.



Youth at the vanguard

The resoluteness of the protests forced the government to step back

A government that does not bend to the will of the people risks being broken. The resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister, after a sustained agitation by youth led by the satirically named Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), is more than just a ministerial casualty of the “paper leaks” scandal. It is a seminal moment in the unravelling of what political scientists describe as the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-dominant party system in Indian democracy, which allows little elbow room for a fragmented Opposition. Entrance examinations are the gatekeeping mechanism that determines which young Indians get to enter the narrow but reassuring world of formal employment later on, in a country where most work remains in the grinding unorganised sector. Repeated leaks across several examinations have turned an apparatus for testing merit into one of widespread graft. Close to 20 lakh candidates were made to take the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate) again after gruelling preparation that coincided with their school examinations. Several students did not survive the ordeal. The grievance bound youth across castes and religions, the very identities that political mobilisation in India has been confined to in recent years. Bypassing a television establishment largely aligned with the ruling dispensation, the faceless protesters built support on social media within days. The high-handedness of the Delhi police and the attempts to throttle the Internet and mobility around the protest venues only swelled their ranks. The government eventually found that this agitation could not be crushed, swayed, split, distracted or left to dissipate, as others have been over the past 12 years. It was forced to negotiate, and in the face of the CJP’s rightful stubbornness, Mr. Pradhan’s continuation became untenable. The nothing-to-lose desperation of the protesters gained a political halo that came from their non-alignment with electorally focused established parties. This was a movement that could not be hijacked or undermined by the political elite, whether of the Opposition or of the government.

But Mr. Pradhan’s announcement of his resignation does not inspire confidence. Instead of accepting moral responsibility for the failures in the conduct and the marking of various examinations, he tactfully sought to present his stepping down as an attempt to prevent “anti-national” elements from exploiting the situation created by the protests. Evident in his resignation letter is the government’s mindset that sections of the students were acting against the Indian state with ulterior motives. This is also part of the same narrative that prompted the Delhi Police to meet the protests with shock batons, pellet guns, and lathi with nails. The police actions were nothing short of calculated brutality that violated all protocols of crowd control. The resignation is a tactical retreat on the part of the government, not a realisation of mistakes made; it came after the abject failure of efforts to paint the protests as communal, as inspired by foreign agencies, and as designed for political mileage. Among the several missteps, the government first acted as if the social media followers were made up of mostly bots who would vanish from view if their accounts were withheld, then as if their virtual presence would have no real-life consequences, and finally as if they could be fought off with Instagram reels. Only on encountering failure after failure did the government get Mr. Pradhan to sign off. But, commendably, the protesters withdrew the agitation once their demands were met.

In the days ahead, the impact of the protests will be far wider than what the government hopes to restrict it to. Over the years, the Narendra Modi-led BJP government has converted mostly narrow electoral victories – a plurality of votes yielding a majority of seats, singly or in coalition – into expansive mandates. It has used them to break the constitutionalist consensus on settled questions of secularism and federalism, advancing a unitary, majoritarian agenda by creeping degrees. It has simultaneously raised its floor of support by radicalising sections in the north, west and now the east of India on the communal plank, which has in turn helped secure its legislative strength. It has recast dissent as anti-national or separatist and hollowed out the Opposition through induced defections and selective deployment of enforcement agencies. Combined with the pusillanimity of other institutions, including a passive judiciary, this has led to what many describe as a managed democracy living under an undeclared emergency for civil liberties. A nation born of non-violent struggle has needed, more than once since Independence, a non-parliamentary convulsion to turn its institutions back towards the vision of the freedom-fighting generation that framed the Constitution. The CJP, and those who stood with it – Sonam Wangchuk fasted for 26 days – have shown that a just demand, pressed through the quintessentially Indian route of satyagraha, can outlast the state’s brutality and move an inflexible government to action. This is a lesson for the institutions charged with checking the executive, and for those charged with questioning authority, especially the media, which – barring some notable exceptions – have mostly played a negative role. They must play their constitutionally mandated and socially responsible role rather than give in to browbeating or expediency. Whether they do so will be tested as the government sets about reforming the entrance examination system with a different Minister in charge. What is certain is that India is yearning for change and rejuvenation.

A volatile political climate in Washington has triggered a wave of strategic anxiety in New Delhi. Buffeted by the transactional, often erratic policy shifts of the Donald Trump administration – which hit India last year with punitive tariffs on steel and aluminium, stripped its preferential trade status, and aggressively renewed ties with Islamabad while imposing irritants such as tightening H-1B visa rules – a growing chorus of domestic voices is calling for a fundamental reset of India’s China policy.

Economic actors, their flawed line

The argument, championed largely by an influential business lobby, suggests that India’s confrontational approach toward Beijing was overly synchronised with Washington’s strategic agenda of “containment” rather than India’s national interests. The lobby contends that because India remains deeply reliant on Chinese technology, supply chains, industrial inputs, and capital, a dogmatic anti-China stance ultimately stymies domestic economic growth while barely denting Beijing’s economy. The core risk, critics warn, is Washington’s historical pattern of tactical flip-flops – escalating tensions one day and striking bilateral deals the next – which risks leaving an overextended India strategically vulnerable to Chinese retaliation.

While the warning against subordinating Indian interests to an unpredictable Washington is entirely valid, it is not clear that this is what is occurring. In any case, the proposed alternative – a hasty, unreciprocated economic embrace of China – is a dangerous prescription. It mistakes tactical business convenience for long-term national security. A premature capitulation to Beijing ignores a decade of unprovoked hostility, deepens an asymmetric dependency, and strips India of its leverage just as the global order enters its most volatile phase since the Cold War.

Let us face it: the primary domestic driver for a China reset is an influential business lobby obsessed with short-term balance sheets. For years, parts of corporate India have argued that access to cheap Chinese capital, machinery, and active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs) is indispensable for India’s growth. However, this view suffers from severe strategic myopia. It treats international trade as an apolitical transaction, completely divorced from the realities of comprehensive national power.

By advocating a return to the pre-2020 status quo, these economic actors choose to selectively forget a dozen years of relentless, unprovoked aggression by the People’s Liberation Army (PLA) and the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). The list of Beijing’s hostile acts against Indian sovereignty is not a series of isolated border skirmishes; it is a coherent strategy of containment and



Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram (Congress party), the Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs and the Sahitya Akademi Award-winning author of 29 books, including ‘Pax Indica’ (2012) and ‘The New World Disorder’ (2020)

Realising that Washington is an unreliable partner does not mean India must run into the arms of an actively hostile neighbour

humiliation. From Depsang (2013) and Chumar (2014) to Doklam (2017) and then the fatal clashes in the Galwan Valley (2020), China has systematically attempted to alter the Line of Actual Control (LAC) through salami-slicing tactics, unilaterally violating decades of border peace protocols. Beijing continues to aggressively assert absurd claims over the entire State of Arunachal Pradesh, renaming geographical features in places it does not control (but plans to), and issuing stapled visas to residents of Jammu and Kashmir and Arunachal to weaponise India’s internal geography.

And then there is economic coercion. China has routinely used its manufacturing dominance as a political weapon, abruptly withholding critical machinery and industrial inputs, even weaponising its monopoly over rare earths and tunnel-boring machines during bilateral disputes, simply to inconvenience Indian industries and signal its leverage, knowing fully that India has none to exercise in return. Most alarming has been Beijing’s overt, coordinated military support for Pakistan during Operation Sindoor (May 2025). By providing Islamabad with real-time tactical satellite data and intelligence, China transformed itself from a mere military supplier into an active, hostile participant in Pakistan’s security architecture against India. To ignore this track record in pursuit of cheaper components is not pragmatism; it is strategic blindness.

The myth of reciprocity

The core flaw in the argument for a quick reset is the naive assumption that if India relaxes its economic guard, China will reciprocate with geopolitical goodwill. The foundational tenet of Chinese foreign policy in Asia is the establishment of a unipolar continent. Beijing does not view New Delhi as a peer, nor does it desire India to become one.

For over a decade, China has weaponised its veto at the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) to shield Pakistan-based terrorist organisations from international sanctions and condemnation. It has blocked India’s legitimate aspirations for permanent membership in the UNSC and membership in the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG). If India opens the floodgates to Chinese capital and market access without any fundamental resolution of the border dispute or a halt to Beijing’s hostile behaviour, it effectively subsidises its own encirclement. Pouring billions of dollars into Chinese coffers as a compliant consumer market merely expands the asymmetric trade deficit (China’s annual surplus over India now exceeds \$100 billion). More dangerously, it hands Beijing an economic kill-switch over the Indian economy. In a future crisis, the threat of cutting off critical components could paralyse Indian industry,

rendering New Delhi incapable of independent strategic decision-making.

Advocates of a reset argue that easing economic tensions could pave the way for a permanent demarcation of the border. In reality, the opposite is true. China respects power and exploits vulnerability. If India surrenders its economic leverage and signals that it cannot sustain a prolonged stand-off, Beijing will conclude that its strategy of multi-domain pressure is working. China will simply bide its time, allowing India to grow comfortably dependent once again. When Beijing eventually decides it is ready to discuss a permanent border settlement, it will dictate terms from a position of absolute dominance. An India structurally dependent on Chinese technology and cowed by the threat of economic disruption will have no choice but to accept a deeply disadvantageous territorial status quo.

Leverage, once surrendered, cannot be easily reclaimed. The restrictions India placed on Chinese apps, investments, and telecom infrastructure post-Galwan were not just emotional reactions; they were crucial diplomatic leverage. Dismantling them for minor economic relief would be an act of unilateral disarmament.

India is undeniably in a complex position. The Trump administration’s unpredictable shifts mean that relying entirely on Washington as a security guarantor is unwise, despite the enthusiasm of his emissary to India, Sergio Gor. The United States will always prioritise its own domestic and global calculations, and New Delhi must remain clear-eyed that it stands alone on the heights of Ladakh. However, realising that Washington is an unreliable partner does not mean India must run into the arms of an actively hostile neighbour. There is an immense strategic space between subordinating India’s national interests to the U.S. and conceding an unconditional economic and political surrender to China.

The path India must tread

The correct path for New Delhi is one of strategic patience and internal fortifying. India must accelerate its supply chain resilience, diversify its trade partnerships across Europe, East Asia, and the Global South, and aggressively build up its domestic manufacturing capabilities – even if it comes with short-term inflationary costs. The last decade has proven that China presents a structural, generational challenge to India’s rise. A hasty rethink driven by panic over Washington or the complaints of a short-term-profit-driven business lobby will only ensure that India remains permanently exposed, economically vulnerable, and strategically diminished.

We do not have to “tilt” either way. We must, instead, develop the strength to walk straight.

The youth have risen against authoritarianism

The Prime Minister blinked. The government blinked. Unfortunately, the blinking was over something that was never called for in the yesteryears of politics. A Railway Minister would resign, in those times, following a terrible railway accident.

Not that it was his personal negligence. But he took responsibility as the ultimate authority. Unfortunately, that sense of honour, self-respect, and decency is lost in politics today. The cars with red lights, a house in Lutyens’ Delhi, and a false sense of aggrandisement is now the priority.

The resignation of an Education Minister, which should have been immediate – following the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate) catastrophe – became an issue requiring a huge protest. The reparation of the damage and taking serious and sincere measures to quell the rot in the education system (alas, just one of the many in various departments) required a protest of the magnitude one has seen, to make the government decide to actually perform its duty, function, and responsibility.

People remain the masters

But one very great takeaway and benefit that has come out of this (for, after all, every negative has



C. Arvama Sundaram

Senior Advocate in the Supreme Court of India

Without any religious or other artificial divides, the youth of India have shown the courage that their elders lacked

the prospect of resulting in something positive) is that an authoritarian government which had grown to believing, and behaving, like it was a body, a party, above the people, with its threats and possible vindictiveness, to anyone who did not “toe the line”, realised that, when you suppress the people, in the end, they are the masters, and the self-important government functionaries are but their servants.

In a way, the NEET incident has been a positive development in the current Indian landscape. At last people have risen against authoritarianism, against fear, against the threat of reprisal, from those who are given power by the very people they now consistently let down. The threat of government reprisal against those who protest or object. The threat of being planted with drugs or false rape charges and of being incarcerated without bail, in the belief that a pliant judicial system would blink, and turn away from injustice, has finally found people, and fortunately the youth of this country who say, “this much and no more”.

Standing united

I am proud of the youth. They have risen as one. With no religious or other artificial divides. They

have shown the courage that elders, who had the wherewithal to show, lacked. They have shown us that cowardice, impotence, and a willingness to bow to such authoritarianism as pliant and obedient cattle, to safeguard the positions we have reached without inviting any unrest or destabilisation of our own self-comfort, are unacceptable. Go forth youth. You are not cockroaches. We elders will hopefully find the courage, through your strength, to stop being cockroaches and shed our fears, and not be protective of our own survival.

Courage against unchecked power

The greatest threat to authoritarianism is when it is taken too far and to such sectors that cannot and will not tolerate it anymore. This has been a protest not just against the NEET debacle, but also against the authoritarian rule that prevails. From the heart of a man known to be completely apolitical, and who has judged each issue on the strength of its own right or wrong, unmindful of whether the ruling dispensation or the Opposition is to blame, all I can say is – may this swing against authoritarianism spearheaded by the youth succeed, so that we can all truly say ‘Jai Hind’.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Youth power triumphs

The government rarely blinks, having retreated only twice this decade: first over the contentious farm laws, and now in the face of widespread youth anger over systemic failures in national examinations. Standard strategies to diffuse resistance, including the use of force and attempts to discredit the agitation, backfired against a disciplined, decentralised, and digitally savvy youth movement. Crucially, this protest drew participation from social groups within the ruling party’s core support base, making prolonged resistance electorally costly. While the removal of the Union Education Minister is aimed at projecting responsiveness, it exposes a rare vulnerability: a muscular administration struggles when confronted

by a self-sustaining, non-partisan public movement with legitimate demands. However, political Opposition parties have little reason to celebrate; the youth’s success only highlights the failure of organised politics to serve as an effective platform for public grievances. The renewal of Indian democracy increasingly rests in the hands of a vigilant civil society. The imperative now is structural reform to restore complete integrity and trust in competitive examination bodies.

S. Padmanabhan,
Kochi, Kerala

The demonstrations have also sent a strong message to the (electronic) media, prompting questions about its role and credibility. Many protesters referred to television news channels as

“Godi Media” and prevented them from covering the protest. This has reinforced the perception among many that sections of the electronic media are biased in favour of the government. As the fourth pillar of democracy, the media must now reflect on its role and strive for greater transparency, balance, and credibility.

Dattaprasad Shirodkar,
Mumbai

The 26-day fast by Sonam Wangchuk and the agitations across India are more than sufficient proof that the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (Undergraduate) should be abolished. The scale of the protests has highlighted the student community’s immense frustration with the Union Government. The BJP government’s

insistence on maintaining its stand despite widespread unrest across the country suggested that it was more interested in preserving majoritarian politics than in upholding democratic values.

N.G.R. Prasad,
Chennai

Gen Z has led the way. The veil of invincibility surrounding the Narendra Modi government has certainly fallen, thanks to the success of the ‘Monsoon Revolution’ spearheaded by the Cockroach Janta Party. India’s conventional mainstream political parties have much to learn from the spirited and no-nonsense conduct of the protests, which were free of extraneous influences. The political landscape will hopefully undergo a positive churn if all stakeholders approach

politics with passion, vision, and unbiased judgment.

Ayyasserri Raveendranath,
Aranmula, Kerala

The way Gen Z sought accountability from an authoritarian regime was courageous. But the Minister’s resignation is not the real success. The main problems lie within the system, and Gen Z seems to be forgetting this. If one Minister resigns, another will take their place and do whatever the higher authority demands. If we want accountability from politicians, we must recognise the power of the ballot. It is the only way to make politicians fear public opinion. The resignation is not the solution; it is like changing the tyres of a motorbike when the engine itself is at fault.

K. Jashwanth,
Hyderabad

While leaders must be held accountable for genuine failures, making resignation the immediate response to every protest can set a dangerous precedent. It may encourage groups to organise demonstrations for every issue, expecting resignations instead of constructive solutions. This could lead to political instability, frequent disruptions, and weaken democratic institutions. Public protests are essential in a democracy, but accountability should follow fair investigations and due process, not public pressure alone. Governments must address grievances responsibly while ensuring that governance remains stable and effective.

Navya Saraf,
Hyderabad

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Indian Monsoon: a democratic tipping point

India stands at an important moment in its democratic journey. Large student demonstrations which were demanding fairness in examinations and Sonam Wangchuk's prolonged fast and hospitalisation along with the start of the Monsoon session of Parliament have together captured the nation's attention. These events viewed together tell a larger story. They signal a growing desire and demand among citizens to be heard, to participate, and shape India's democratic future.

This moment can be described as the Indian Monsoon.

Just as the annual monsoon follows months of intense heat, societies too experience seasons when accumulated aspirations, frustrations, and exclusion seek peaceful democratic expression. Such moments should not be feared. They should be welcomed as opportunities for reflection, dialogue, reform and redesign.

On imagining a future

India has much to celebrate. The country has expanded digital public infrastructure, modernised transportation, strengthened financial inclusion, and demonstrated achievements in science, technology, and space. These accomplishments have brought recognition for India.

At the same time, many young Indians worry about the credibility of competitive examinations, access to quality education, and the availability of meaningful employment. Farmers continue to face economic uncertainty and income inequality remains a major concern. Public discourse has become increasingly polarised, with many citizens questioning institutional autonomy, the role of the media, the undermining of civil society, and the quality of democratic debate. These concerns should not be viewed through a partisan lens. They should be understood as democratic signals.

The strength of a democracy is measured not by the absence of



Sam Pitroda
Telecom inventor, entrepreneur, development thinker, and policy maker

Our future depends upon combining technological excellence with constitutional values, scientific temper, ethical leadership, and respect for humanity

criticism but by its willingness to listen and reform.

India's greatest asset has always been its extraordinary diversity – of languages, religions, castes, cultures, traditions, trade, ideas, and aspirations. The Indian Constitution transformed that diversity into the foundation of national unity. It affirmed that justice, liberty, equality, and fraternity are not just abstract ideals but practical principles for governing a vibrant society.

As India moves toward the centenary of its Independence in 2047, there is an opportunity to renew that constitutional promise. The real question is: what kind of India do we want to build for the next generation? Do we aspire merely to become a larger economy, or do we seek to become a more inclusive, more equitable, more scientific, more innovative, more peaceful and compassionate society?

This Monsoon moment calls for a new national agenda.

The government must restore complete confidence in our education and examination systems. It must create millions of meaningful jobs by encouraging decentralisation, district-level development, entrepreneurship, innovation, and local manufacturing. It must also strengthen public healthcare, improve nutrition, low-cost housing, safety, security, schools, vocational training, invest in scientific research, reduce bureaucracy, and expand technology and opportunities for every young Indian, regardless of their background.

Above all, India must prepare for the age of Artificial Intelligence (AI). AI is not simply another technological revolution. It will reshape and redefine work, education, healthcare, agriculture, manufacturing, communities, villages, cities, governance and employment.

India possesses the raw young talent, entrepreneurial spirit, and digital foundation to become a global leader in AI for public good.

Its challenge is to ensure that technology serves every citizen sustainably. No algorithm can replace trust and no AI system can replace human wisdom.

Our future therefore depends upon combining technological excellence with constitutional values, scientific temper, ethical leadership, and respect for humanity.

The idea of India

Perhaps, the greatest challenge before India today is not economic or technological. It is philosophical – the idea of India rooted in our Constitution. That ideology needs to be the core of our development, and the prerequisite for a path to prosperity. For far too long has the world measured success primarily through the pursuit of power and profit. The time has come to rebalance our priorities: to place people and the planet at the centre of development. If we empower every young person, reduce inequality, strengthen democratic institutions, focus on humanity and not religion, and use technology to expand opportunity rather than privilege, India can offer the world a new developmental model – one that combines economic progress with human dignity.

The Indian Monsoon is therefore not a political movement. It is a democratic season of renewal. It reminds us that governments derive strength by listening to their citizens, and that India's greatest achievements have always come when we have chosen dialogue over division.

History will judge us by whether we had the wisdom to listen, the courage to reform, and the imagination to build an India worthy of its civilisational heritage and its democratic promise.

If we seize this moment with humility, confidence and vision, the Indian Monsoon will not merely mark another season of public debate. It will mark the beginning of India's next democratic renaissance.

A gamble on the Cauvery issue

CM Vijay aims to hold direct talks with Karnataka for water-sharing

STATE OF PLAY

T. Ramakrishnan

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) president C. Joseph Vijay's decision to initiate talks with his Karnataka counterpart D. K. Shivakumar on the Cauvery issue marks a departure from the State's traditional policy over the Cauvery dispute.

The purpose of Mr. Vijay's visit to Bengaluru is to impress on the upper riparian State the imperative for it to release the share of water due to Tamil Nadu, as stipulated in the final award of the Cauvery Water Disputes Tribunal (CWDT) in 2007 which was amended by the Supreme Court 11 years later. Between June 1 and July 23, the State should have realised around 32 thousand million cubic feet (tmc ft) of water but what it got was about 3.5 tmc ft. Keeping in mind the deficient rainfall from the southwest monsoon over the river's catchment and its own formula of proportionate reduction, Tamil Nadu feels that it should have received at least three tmc ft more.

A new strategy

Mr. Vijay's outreach has evoked disapproval from many political parties, farmers' leaders, and experts alike, as direct negotiations, in their assessment, would amount to bypassing the established implementation mechanism – the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) and the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee – as per the final award and the Court's judgment. Besides, Tamil Nadu has been, since the CWDT's establishment in June 1990, a strong votary of adjudication to resolve the vexatious pro-



blem of sharing river water in contrast to its neighbour's preference for talks. On several occasions, it had outrightly spurned offers for talks made by various leaders of Karnataka. In the last 35-odd years, there were occasions when the State took part in bilateral and multilateral discussions but this was part of the Supreme Court's intervention.

Even though the CWDT's formation itself was an outcome of the failure of 26 rounds of negotiations held over 22 years, Mr. Vijay seems to be receptive to the idea of chalking out a path that his predecessors did not favour. What should be helpful to him is that in Karnataka, the ruling party is the Congress, a junior partner in his coalition government. The Congress' former president, Rahul Gandhi, was a prominent attendee at Mr. Vijay's swearing-in event in May. Further, Mr. Shivakumar himself was among the early leaders from other States to greet Mr. Vijay on becoming the Chief Minister. It is possible that the TVK chief has thought of capitalising on his equations with Mr. Shivakumar and the Congress party to break new ground in the Cauvery problem.

At the same time, Mr. Vijay should know, by now, that personal relationships and striking a deal on contentious and long-standing disputes are two distinct matters. After all, many of his predecessors,

especially M. Karunanidhi and M.G. Ramachandran (MGR), had equally good, if not better, ties with their Karnataka peers such as Veerendra Patil, D. Devaraj Urs, R. Gundu Rao, Ramakrishna Hegde, and J.H. Patel. Rao had even invited MGR, according to diplomat-political writer R. Kannan's biography on the latter, to join the Congress after his exit from the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam in 1972.

Nine years later, MGR, as Chief Minister, visited Bengaluru in October 1981 originally for a day's talks with Rao but had to extend his stay by one more day. Even then, no breakthrough was achieved.

It is well known that when it came to the Cauvery, the upper riparian State's Chief Ministers would give substantive nothing to the other side.

Clubbing of issues

What is also troubling several parties and groups in Tamil Nadu over the proposed talks is the possibility of the Karnataka government using this occasion to raise the Mekedatu dam project, which the lower riparian State has been opposing on the ground that it will jeopardise its irrigation requirements. There is substance in their apprehension but Tamil Nadu has to convey to Karnataka that it can have talks separately, as and when necessary, as it has sought the formation of an exclusive tribunal to handle the subject. For the time being, its focus is on obtaining immediate relief from Karnataka in terms of water release.

If the two States go beyond and agree on a distress water-sharing formula which can be presented to the CWMA for ratification, it will be a real feather in Mr. Vijay's cap.

ramakrishnan.t@thehindu.co.in

Need to shift focus to rising student suicides, cost of education

As the protests led by the CJP end, larger systemic issues associated with high-stakes entrance examinations such as NEET need to be addressed

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy

The sustained protests led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) demanding accountability over paper leaks in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) came to an end on Saturday with the government accepting many of their demands, including the resignation of Union Minister of Education Dharmendra Pradhan, compensation for the families of the deceased who ended their lives over the NEET paper leaks, and the withdrawal of criminal cases against protesters.

Thousands of protesters who gathered across many places in the country despite crackdown by the government, including brutal police action in Delhi on July 20, have termed Mr. Pradhan's resignation a 'historic win'. While their demands have successfully pinned accountability for a leaked question paper, larger questions around high-stakes entrance exams – the NEET in particular – such as the proliferation of coaching centres, increased expenditure for families, and high levels of stress experienced by students, remain unaddressed.

Over 20 lakh students appeared for NEET in the first week of May. Reports indicate that more than a dozen students died by suicide after the exam was cancelled and rescheduled due to widespread allegations of question papers getting leaked. These suicides cannot be seen in isolation. The number of student suicides increased by about 80% from 8,068 in 2014 to 14,488 in 2024, the latest year for which the Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (ADSI) report by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) has been published.

Over 1.23 lakh students ended their lives between 2014 and 2024 in the country (**Chart 1**).

The Ministry of Education stated in Parliament that suicides

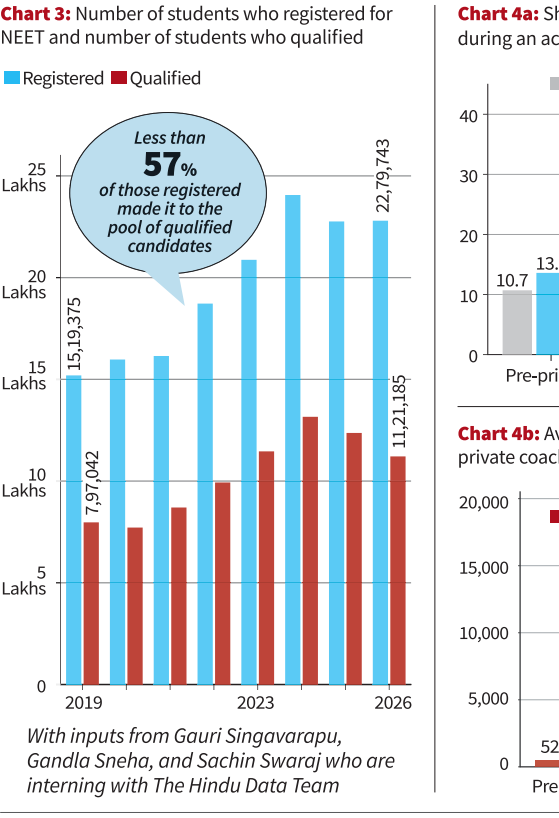
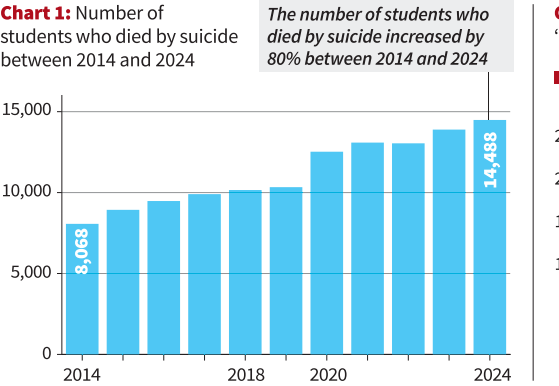
among students are driven by various causes such as academic stress, family problems, mental health issues, financial distress and interpersonal conflicts. The ADSI reports capture "failure in examination" as a distinct category of reason for suicides. Suicides for which "failure in examination" was the primary reason accounted for 21%, or more than one-fifth, of the total number of student suicides between 2014 and 2024. Over 2,000 students died every year due to failure in examinations, with 2021 being the only exception. Cumulatively, over 25,000 students died by suicide due to failure in exams between 2014 and 2024, of which 55% were under 18 years and another 42% between 18 and 30 years of age (**Chart 2**).

Though student suicides cannot be seen in the context of NEET alone, this highly competitive medical entrance exam has come to symbolise these systemic issues. The exam has repeatedly come under focus for issues such as paper leaks, inhumane levels of checking of students while entering exam halls, and concerns over unusually high-scoring patterns from select centres. Over 15 lakh students have registered for the NEET examination every year since 2015. However, those who made it to the pool of qualified candidates is less than 57% (**Chart 3**).

Moreover, the need to join private coaching and the reality that many have to repeat the exam after studying for another year or two to qualify have contributed to significant costs for households. More than 35% of secondary and higher secondary students attend private coaching. In fact, households' private coaching expenses is about a third of their entire education expenditure (**Chart 4**).

While the protests have come to an end, at least temporarily, these systemic problems await closure.

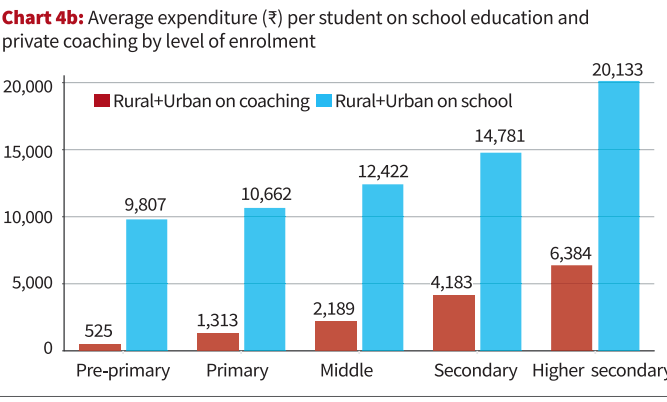
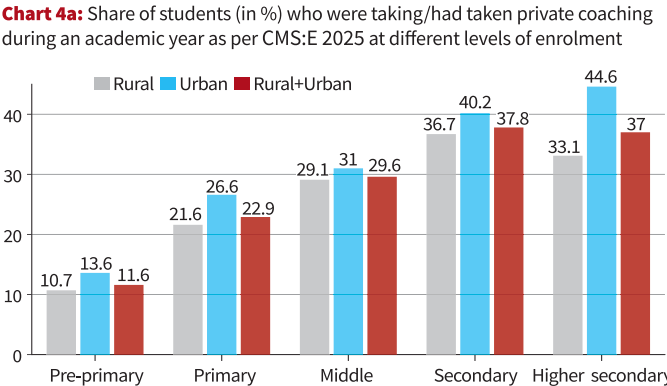
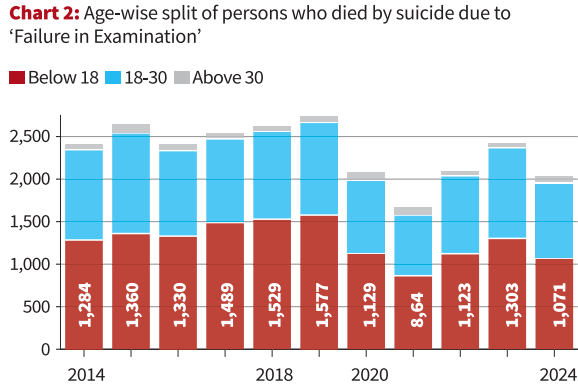
(Assistance for overcoming suicidal thoughts is available on TeleMANAS 14416 and Sneha's suicide prevention helpline 044-24640050)



Under pressure

The data for the charts were sourced from the National Testing Agency's press releases, the Accidental Deaths and Suicides in India (ADSI) reports, and Comprehensive Modular survey: Education 2025 (CMS:E 2025)

Carrying the flame: Supporters lighting candles to pay homage to the students who died by suicide after the NEET paper leak during the third day of protests by the Cockroach Janta Party, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on June 22. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA / THE HINDU



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 27, 1976

'Roman letter' on Mars rock

Pasadena (California), July 26: Commands relayed to Mars from U.S. scientists on earth apparently straightened out a hitch in Viking's soil-sampling arm yesterday.

But another key experiment the seismology probe, appeared to be beyond the reach of earth-bound repairmen.

Pictures from the Viking lander on Sunday showed a tiny lockpin lying on the Martian dust. That meant the pin believed to have caused the jamming of the soil sampler's arm, had fallen away as planned.

Late last week after the problem cropped up scientists discovered through a model of the lander at the Jet Propulsion Laboratory (JPL) that by extending the arm a bit the problem pin would drop free. That was what happened yesterday on Mars, scientists said.

"Everybody is very happy about it and we are ready to move right along," said the Viking Project Manager, Mr. James Martin. "We are moving right on ahead."

New closeup pictures of the Chryse plain on Mars revealed what appeared to be a rock bearing the Roman letters "B" and "C" and the Arabic numeral "2". Scientists said the characters were optical illusions caused by shadowing.

"People are great at imagining things", said Dr. Carl Sagan. Dr. Bruce Murray, Director of the Jet Propulsion laboratory agreed.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 27, 1926

Growing chaos in China

An "Englishman" cable from London dated July 25, states:—

Mr. Percival London, cabling to the "Daily Telegraph" from Peking, declares that China is on the verge of bankruptcy.

He says it is difficult to describe the intense feeling of pessimism reigning among all classes. China is in a state of helpless chaos and local tyranny is blasting any hope of extricating any part of the country from the welter of militarism and corruption. The situation can only be retrieved if the slackness of Europe is abandoned and a genuine attempt made by the Powers to act unitedly.

The steady and impartial administration of the Customs under Sir Francis Aglen, enabling the collection of revenues, is the one bright spot in a gloomy pasture.

From Page One

Nilekani to lead task force on exam reforms

Mr. Nilekani has worked with the Union government in the past to set up the Aadhaar ecosystem and Unified Payments Interface (UPI). He is also the chairperson of the governing body of the economic policy research think tank, the National Council of Applied Economic Research (NCAER), and a co-founder of Infosys.

Joshi takes charge

After assuming charge of the Education Ministry, Mr. Joshi told the media, “The Prime Minister has entrusted me with this responsibility with full confidence. I was in Karnataka yesterday. I reached here last night and came this morning to take charge. I have assumed charge.”

“I am reviewing all the details here and the decisions that need to be taken. I have been gathering information and trying to understand the functioning of the Ministry. We had continuous meetings today. This is a new subject for me. I have taken charge today and held detailed discussions with the senior officers. It is a very big department, so I will speak to you in detail after I have understood it completely,” Mr. Joshi stated.

Union Minister of State for Education Jayant Chaudhary attended the meeting. Officials said Mr. Joshi reviewed key schemes, including Samagra Shiksha, PM-SHRI Schools and PM POSHAN, and discussed school infrastructure.

Higher Education Department Secretary, School Education and Literacy Department Secretary, and other senior officials of the Ministry were present.

Centre warns Indians about jobs in Black Sea

Indian seafarers were urged to follow all the advisories issued by the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, including one issued on July 23.

Search and rescue under way

The latest advisory came a day after the *MV AGN Ragnar* was struck at the port of Odesa. “Four Indian nationals were on board the vessel. As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals. Search and rescue operations are under way. The Embassy is in constant touch with the concerned authorities,” the Indian Embassy in Kyiv said, without specifying who had fired the projectile that hit the ship.

Earlier on July 19, the *MV Golden Leo*, a Guinea Bissau-flagged ship, was also hit by projectiles that led to the deaths of 10 seafarers, of whom four were Indian citizens. This incident had prompted the MEA to summon the chargé d'affaires of the Russian Embassy in India. External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar met his Russian counterpart Sergey Lavrov on the sidelines of the East Asia Summit in Manila on July 22, where he expressed “strong concern regarding the safety of Indian seafarers in the region”.

Subsequently, Kremlin spokesperson Dmitry Peskov said that Russia was in touch with India over the matter. However, he said, “Our armed forces are striking and will continue to strike those vessels that are involved in transporting ammunition, weapons and so on, for the purposes of the Kiev regime.”

Responding to this assertion, MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal pointed out that the ship was civilian in nature. “As per the information that was made available to us by the Directorate General of Maritime Administration, this particular ship, *Golden Leo*, was Guinea-Bissau-flagged on which we lost four of our nationals. It loaded grain as cargo prior to leaving the port of Odesa and this happened on 19th July. We once again reiterate that commercial shipping and seafarers should not be attacked under any circumstances,” he said.

Iran says it is halting ‘retaliatory strikes’

Soon after the war started, Iran said it had laid mines along the central part of the Strait traditionally used for merchant ship navigation and designated a “safe” route along its coast, an effective way to extend its control over the Strait.

Iran said on Sunday that it had made progress in talks with neighbouring Oman, which holds the opposite coast of the Strait, on “common principles and operational mechanisms” for ships in the Strait. While the two nations had come up with a proposal in June to jointly administer the Strait and monetise it, the U.S. had refused to accept any Iranian control. Oman had also gone ahead and announced a route along its coast for ships to use that was endorsed by the International Maritime Organization, but angered Iran.

Mixed signals

Meanwhile, the U.S. media has reported that the country’s plans to escalate the war have been shelved, in part because of shrinking armament supplies. On Friday, however, U.S. President Donald Trump said that Iran had a choice between a deal and strikes at a “much higher level”, adding, “We’re talking to them right now. I think they’re getting more and more serious.” Fighting reportedly continued between the Iran-backed Houthi militia and Saudi Arabia, with the Houthis claiming to have downed a Saudi drone, a day after claiming to have attacked Saudi oil facilities.

Tejashwi Yadav demands release of brother, others

Bihar’s Leader of Opposition warns of massive agitation if protesters are not released in 24 hours; seeks govt. action against police personnel who ‘opened fire at students’ at Siwan and Jehanabad

Amit Bhelari
PATNA

Lashing out at the State police for the arrest of hundreds of agitators during the Bihar Bandh, Leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav on Sunday demanded the immediate release of students, Opposition MLAs, and other protesters, including his elder brother Tej Pratap Yadav. If they are not released within 24 hours, he warned the State government that they would hit the streets once again.

The Bihar Bandh was called by the All India Students’ Association (AISA) on Saturday. It turned violent in places and resulted in clashes with the police, who opened fire in Siwan, while hundreds were arrested.

Among those arrested was Mr. Tej Pratap, who is no longer a member of the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and has formed his own political outfit. He was arrested by the Patna Police on charges of obstructing government officials from discharging their duties and sent to judicial custody for 14 days in Beur Jail. “The Centre decided



Leader of the Opposition Tejashwi Yadav meets an injured protester at a hospital in Patna on Sunday. ANI

yesterday to withdraw all the cases against the protesting students and youth [in Delhi]. The [Bihar] government should follow suit,” Mr. Tejashwi told presspersons at Patna airport, where he was accompanied by his mother and former Chief Minister Rabri Devi.

“Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary must release everyone, including my brother, within 24 hours or be ready to face a massive agitation, and students and youth will once again hit the roads to protest,” he added.

The RJD leader also asked the government to

express their dissent and ideas, holding unchecked power accountable,” he said in a post on X after meeting the protesters.

‘Minors also arrested’

Disha Students’ Organisation member Soma Roy told *The Hindu* that many students have been arrested by the Patna Police, including some minors.

“As many as 11 FIRs have been lodged against protesting students in different police stations in the State since July 22. Some of them are even minors, and their parents contacted me to check about their well-being. The State police must release them immediately as they have been wrongfully detained,” Ms. Roy said.

Others who were arrested include Sandeep Saurav, the Communist Party of India (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation’s Paliganj MLA and leaders of the AISA State unit, including president Dhananjay.

Youth organisations announced that a Virodh Diwas, or day of protest, will be observed across Bihar on July 30, against the police action and the illegal arrest of student leaders, including the Mr. Saurav.

Assam CM plays down Minister’s daughter joining CJP protest in Guwahati

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma has sought to play down the participation of the daughter of one of his Cabinet Ministers in a Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest in Guwahati on July 23.

Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Keshab Mahanta was trolled after videos of his daughter Dibisa Mahanta shouting slogans at a CJP protest against alleged irregularities in the NEET exam went viral.

One of the slogans took a dig at Prime Minister Narendra Modi.



Himanta Biswa Sarma

she “may not follow her father’s political ideology”.

“Tomorrow, when my son practices law, he may defend someone whom I may not like. The actions of children should not be linked to their parents once they become adults,” Mr. Sarma told presspersons on Saturday.

‘Will speak to her’

“I do not agree with the slogans she raised. When I meet her, I will speak to her about it and try to make her understand that it was not the right thing to say,” he said.

Mr. Mahanta is one of two AGP Ministers in the BJP-led Assam government.

M.P. man booked over ‘abusive’ reel on Pradhan

The Hindu Bureau
BHOPAL

A social media content creator has been booked in Madhya Pradesh’s Niwari district for allegedly using “highly abusive” language against former Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the BJP and the Delhi Police in a video clip amid the student agitation.

According to the police, the accused, Yashpal Soni, a social media influencer, was booked on July 23 over an Instagram reel he had posted and has been questioned in the matter.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Niwari Superintendent of Police Ray Singh Narwaria said that the video was “way out of the purview of freedom of expression.”

The reframing of the political narrative by Gen Z

NEWS ANALYSIS

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

“All is well.” The line from *Three Idiots* became an anthem of optimism for an entire generation. The film portrayed the story of three friends trying to break free from the rigid expectations imposed by India’s education system.

Aamir Khan played Rancho, whose real identity in the film was Phunsukh Wangdu, an engineer and innovator living in Ladakh. The character was widely believed to have been inspired by innovator-turned-activist Sonam Wangchuk, who later emerged as the face of the anti-paper leak protests at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar.

Ironically, the protest site represented the exact inversion of the film’s celebrated refrain. Students and young people from diverse social and economic



Protesters celebrate at Jantar Mantar after Dharmendra Pradhan resigned as Education Minister on Saturday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

backgrounds gathered to send a simple message: all was not well.

Their objective was not merely to force the government to acknowledge their concerns over recurring examination paper leaks, but also to assert that their individual stories mattered and deserved to be heard.

If the government was the protesters’ primary target, a section of the mainstream media became the second. Reporters from television channels were booed and heckled for pro-

moting what the protesters saw as a biased narrative.

For much of the BJP’s time in office, critics have accused sections of television news of amplifying the government’s narrative. At Jantar Mantar, that criticism found its most visible expression. Posters of several television anchors were displayed, with some protesters branding them “anti-national”.

What made the scenes at Jantar Mantar particularly noteworthy was that this sentiment was being artic-

ulated by Gen Z, a generation often perceived as politically detached. Their rejection of sections of the mainstream media ought to prompt introspection within news organisations.

The protests acquired a sharper political edge after the police action on July 20, involving personnel of the Rapid Action Force and the Delhi Police. Images of students being dragged away and allegations of excessive use of force transformed what began as a movement against paper leaks into a broader expression of youth anxiety about fairness, opportunity and accountability.

“The people of the country have started claiming their country back from those who have tried to destroy the Constitution, from those who have tried everything to suppress the voice of the people,” Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra said. Whether or not one agrees with such a political

characterisation, the protests acquired a significance beyond education reform.

BJP’s tasks ahead

Successive electoral victories have given the BJP an aura of political invincibility, encouraging many of its supporters to ridicule the Opposition with ease. But the government quickly recognised the changing mood, opened channels of communication with the leaders of the protest, and signalled that it was willing to engage. Prime Minister Narendra Modi himself reached out to young people through video messages on Instagram, the social media platform most widely used by Gen Z.

The immediate protests may have ended, but the larger political challenge remains. The BJP’s task is not merely to resolve the issue of paper leaks. It is to regain the trust of Gen Z, a demographic that has played a crucial role in propelling the party to power.



Workers paint over slogans and graffiti on a wall near Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

A day later, traces of protest removed from Jantar Mantar

Ashna Butani
NEW DELHI

On Sunday, posters were brought down and graffiti were covered with paint at Jantar Mantar, which hosted a 36-day agitation that culminated on Saturday with the resignation of former Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET question paper leak and other issues.

New Delhi Municipal Corporation (NDMC) officials said that they had conducted a cleanliness and beautification drive at the venue and 60 tonnes of waste had been removed from the site.

The protest drew thousands of protesters, many of them students, and spilled out of Jantar Mantar

on to Tolstoy Road, eventually all the way up to Sansad Marg on one side and Janpath Road on the other.

NMDC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal said from Saturday night, over 500 officers and employees took part in the drive, undertaking cleaning, washing, repair, and restoration of roads, footpaths, central verges, green belts, walls, and other public spaces.

Seventy-five sanitation workers had been deployed throughout the night, while 35 additional workers joined in the morning. The drive was supported by eight auto-tippers, two heavy trucks, one earthmover, and three high-pressure jetting machines.

Who approved assault on students, asks Rahul

Congress leader seeks accountability from Home Minister for 'the use of lethal force, including pellet guns' against students in Delhi; Opposition likely to demand PM's apology in Parliament

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, has sought accountability from Union Home Minister Amit Shah for the "barbaric assault on students who were peacefully protesting in Delhi" on July 20. In a letter on Saturday, he asked Mr. Shah whether the latter had authorised the use of "lethal force".

Opposition parties are likely to raise this issue in Parliament on Monday and demand an apology from Prime Minister Narendra Modi, sources told *The Hindu*.

Mr. Gandhi said peaceful protest was crucial to any democracy and it was the government's responsibility to protect protesters and resolve their grievances through dialogue.

The Congress MP said the students were demanding a fair and accountable education system, but instead of being heard, they were assaulted by security forces with indiscriminate force, including lethal weapons and tear gas.

"Hundreds have suffered serious injuries. Women students have been assaulted by policemen, including by deliberately targeting their private parts. Most shocking has been the use of lethal pellet guns," Mr. Gandhi said in the letter, a copy of which was posted on his X handle on Sunday.

He mentioned meeting 19-year-old student Sahil Lochab, who could lose his eyesight because of pellet gun wounds.

"As Home Minister, did you approve the use of lethal force including pel-



Rahul Gandhi speaks to media on the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan in New Delhi on Saturday. @INCINDIA

lets under Rule 267 seeking suspension of business to discuss "use of excessive force on student protesters during NEET examination protest". Trinamool Congress's Sagarika Ghosh said, "It is extremely shocking that that such extreme coercive measures were taken on unarmed students and youth. Government needs to give us answers on who authorised the use of pellet guns."

Asked if the RAF was authorised to use pellet guns, G.P. Singh, Director-General, Central Reserve Police Force, told *The Hindu*, "Now, since agitation has been called off, and assembled people have dispersed, we would make a professional post-event assessment, like we do after every major assignment, and then let you know the view of the Force Headquarters."

Asked if the Opposition would disrupt proceedings in Parliament, Mr. Gandhi said it would be decided in the meeting of Opposition leaders on Monday morning.

(With inputs from Sobhana K. Nair and Vijaita Singh)

let guns against students? If not, who did? Are the people in plainclothes seen beating students with lathi police personnel or volunteers? Who authorised their deployment?" Mr. Gandhi asked.

On Saturday, the Opposition leader directly blamed the Home Minister for the use of "lethal weapons and pellet guns" in police action.

"We will not accept our own forces shooting the future of India. So, that is going to be a major issue in Parliament," he said.

Other Opposition leaders have also moved a not-

Students are more important than any post: Home Minister

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI



Amit Shah

Union Home Minister Amit Shah has said that the country, youth, and students are far more important than any position for BJP workers and the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan exemplifies this principle.

His remarks came after Mr. Pradhan resigned on Saturday amid mounting pressure from the protests over NEET question paper leak.

"The Modi government respects the sentiments of the country's youth and is committed to implementing the necessary reforms against paper leaks," he said in a post on X late on Saturday night.

"For the BJP, the nation, our youth and students hold far greater importance than any position," he said.

The decisions taken by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to ensure strict punishment for those guilty of paper leaks are commendable, Mr. Shah said.

"I am fully confident that these steps will ensure complete justice for the students who succeeded in

the NEET examination," the Home Minister said.

'Significant reforms'

Mr. Shah said Mr. Pradhan had brought about significant reforms in the effective implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP), arrangements for examinations in mother tongues, expansion of PM SHRI Schools, promotion of digital education, skill development, and strengthening industry-academia coordination during his tenure.

"His efforts toward making the examination system more inclusive and student-centric have also been noteworthy. His tenure is a testament to his dedication to the resolve of making India a developed nation," he said.

At Mumbai rally, people happy with Pradhan's exit, but slam govt. on E20

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI



People at the 'victory rally' at Shivaji Park in Mumbai to celebrate the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

On a rainy Sunday morning, Shubham Shyam, 32, held a *dafali* (traditional hand drum) and stood outside Mumbai's iconic Shivaji Park, celebrating the resignation of Union Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. "It is time to rest, reset, and then take down Union Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari," he declared.

"We will party for two weeks, then we will play the sugarcane game," Mr. Shyam added, hinting at criticism faced by Mr. Gadkari over the implementation of E20, or ethanol-blended petrol.

Mr. Shyam's thoughts were echoed by other protesters. Aarsh, 25, a content writer, and Rohan, 19, a B.Tech. student, both said "E20 kills vehicles and people's pockets". Mr. Rohan said, "Since 10th grade, I have seen fuel prices skyrocket, and now vehicle mileage is poor, and pure petrol is expensive. Why give us a cheaper E20 option? Make petrol cheaper," said Mr. Rohan.

They were participating in a victory rally called by Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray and Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Raj Thackeray. Thousands of Gen Z and millennials gathered at the rally to celebrate the success of the protest spear-

headed by the Cockroach Janta Party, raising slogans such as "Our right, keep it here", "*Bharat Mata Ki Jai*", "This country is ours, and we belong to this country," and calling for the resignations of Mr. Gadkari and Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

Uddhav slams PM

Mr. Uddhav Thackeray advised Prime Minister Narendra Modi to pay attention to the country, instead of engaging BJP Ministers and MPs to engineer defections. "India has come together; caste, religion, and every other divide is vanishing. It is no more BJP versus the Opposition, but BJP versus the country," said Mr. Thackeray. Mr. Raj Thackeray expressed his gratitude to Mumbai and the Maharashtra Police,

saying, "You are not like the Delhi Police. This is your victory."

Standing next to a row of yellow barricades, animator Mansi Worlikar, 26, and her friends were holding a placard taking a dig at Mr. Modi, who in a recent Instagram video had called the youth his "friends". Ms. Worlikar said, "The victory feels personal, because we fought an impossible mountain and made the crack."

For her friend, entertainment writer Urvashi More, 27, it was an eye-opener that she could have a political opinion and even voice it. "Something in me has moved; I now know that my political opinion matters," said Ms. More.

Tushar Gandhi, great-grandson of Mahatma Gandhi, also joined the vic-

tory party. He said that the youth of the country had chosen their path. "However, the challenge is to make every issue a mass issue and not allow the government to confine it to a particular community, caste, or economic group," Mr. Gandhi added.

'Showing up matters'

The party atmosphere appeared complete with Bluetooth speakers belting out popular Hindi songs and the Gen-Z swaying to the music. In one such group stood Tarini, 23, who said, "We are not saying the system has changed, but there is hope for change. Showing up does matter."

For Anam Khan, 21, a teacher from Sion, the protest felt like a lesson on humanity. "I never felt this equal with Hindus, Jains, or any other community. We saw instances where we were about to get detained and ran holding each other's hands without thinking whether the other person was Hindu or Muslim. That is the beauty I saw here."

Gia, 23, said, "The result is a cosmetic makeover, but at least now we know people in India vote with emotions. But we will vote logically, on facts."

This is a new beginning in seeking accountability from our leaders, Ms. Tarini added.

Hunger strike was challenge to govt., the movement is still on, says AISA secretary

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI



Neha

Six of them sat on a hunger strike, a little away from the main dais at Jantar Mantar where the spotlight was on activist Sonam Wangchuk. Three of the six were still around when Mr. Wangchuk was forcibly shifted to hospital by the police on July 18. On July 25, when Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan announced his resignation, they were still there at the protest venue.

The members of the All India Students' Association (AISA) had sat there for 23 days, as doctors took their blood pressure, conducted ECGs, and pricked their arms for blood tests.

The AISA was among the many student organisations reached out by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), which headlined the protests against exam question paper leaks. Other Left student bodies were also associated with the protests, including the Students Federation of India (SFI), the All India Students Federation (AISF), and the Krantikari Yuva Sangathan (KYS). Many in the Left circles questioned the political affiliations of this newly minted organisation, the CJP, born on social media. Many dismissed it as a

saying that I had to go hungry since they voted for the BJP. Many even cried." The experience that has stayed with her is that of the weeping father of a NEET student who died by suicide. "He said he had voted for the BJP and made everyone in his family vote for the BJP," Ms. Neha said.

'Not about self-sacrifice'

"It was never about self-sacrifice. It was rather a challenge to the government. The question was: will the government let us waste away slowly rather than forcing their Minister to resign?" She said that Mr. Pradhan's resignation was only the first of the many to come. The protest at Jantar Mantar may have ended but the movement has not, she said.

The SFI and AISF sat on hunger strike from July 18-20. SFI president Adarsh M. Saji said his organisation's idea was to take the protest beyond Jantar Mantar. "We organised protests in 24 States," he said.

"We didn't have any confusion about the ultimate goal of this protest. It was clear that it went beyond slogans; it was an agitation to regain democratic space that has been ceded in the last 12 years," CPI(M) Rajya Sabha leader John Brittas said.

RSS women's wing seeks uniform policy on population

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Rashtra Sevika Samiti, the women's parallel of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), on Sunday adopted a resolution expressing concern over what it termed "population imbalance" in the country, urging the Centre and State governments to formulate a uniform national population policy applicable to all communities.

The resolution was passed at the organisation's Akhil Bharatiya Pratidin Sabha (All India Representative Council), held at Samalakhya, was headed by Samiti chief V. Shantha Kumari.

Arguing that population was not merely a statistical measure but determined a nation's future and identity, the resolution stated that while India's population growth rate had declined due to decades of population control measures, demographic changes among religious communities had created an imbalance that warranted a review of the existing population policy.

"The growing demographic imbalance in India is not only eroding the country's identity but is also posing a threat to India's very existence," the resolution read.

Sonam Wangchuk to be discharged from hospital today; will visit Rajghat

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Activist Sonam Wangchuk will be discharged from Medanta Hospital in Gurugram on Monday and will visit Rajghat to pay homage to Mahatma Gandhi before leaving for Ladakh, his team said.

Mr. Wangchuk, who is recovering in the hospital after he broke his 26-day fast late Friday night, is expected to be dis-

charged at around 11.30 am on Monday.

He had paid homage to Mahatma Gandhi at Rajghat, on June 28, before launching his indefinite hunger strike at Jantar Mantar here to support students protesting alleged irregularities, such as question paper leak, in the recently held NEET medical entrance examination.

Mr. Wangchuk had joined the agitation on June 28 and remained on an indefinite fast for

26 days. He was forcibly shifted to Safdarjung Hospital on July 18, where he said he felt like he was being kept in detention. Following a Delhi High Court order, he was shifted to Medanta Hospital.

The 36-day agitation, led by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), ended on Saturday with the resignation of Dharmendra Pradhan as Union Education Minister. The protest had begun on June 20.

KERALA WATER AUTHORITY
E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender No.05/2026-27/SE/PPD/KCH

AMRUT-2.0-Design, Construction, Commissioning, Trial Running, Operation and Maintenance (for a period of 5 years) of 5 MLD capacity STP at Alissery in Alappuzha district along with Design, Construction, Testing and Commissioning of 11.838 km sewage collection network in ward No.34 and 35 (Old) of Alappuzha Municipality and allied works. Cost of Tender form: Rs. 19,518/- (Indisive of GST) EMD: Rs. 5,00,000/- Date and time of Opening Tender: 01/09/2026 at 3.30 pm Last date of receipt of tender: 31/08/2026 at 3.00 pm; Phone:8547638502; E-mail- seppdregionkochi@gmail.com; Website: etenders.kerala.gov.in

Sd/-, Superintending Engineer, PPDJ & Sewerage Circle, KWA, Kochi - 11

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The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec. No: **PMMTCT1-e-37/2026** for floating of tender for Supply, Erection, Testing and Commissioning of MPLS-TP equipment (421 Nos) for establishment of a dedicated communication network for the State Transmission Asset Management Centre (STAMC) at Gunadala, Vijayawada with an MPLS-TP network across all 400kV/220kV/132kV (405 Nos.) substations with 10G and 1G transport networks on all existing OPGW fibre networks Date & Time of availability of Tender on e-procurement platform i.e., www.tender.apeprocurement.gov.in is on **27.07.2026 @17:00Hrs.** Contact No. **Dy.EE: 9491008564** Sd/- Chief Engineer/Telecom & IT

R.O. No.-GMCC/APTRANSCO/107/26-27

**OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER,
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E-mail : seec.bbsr2010@gmail.com

Bid Identification No.S.E.E.C (R&B) 23/2026-27

No.3313 / Date 20.07.2026

The Superintending Engineer, Electrical Circle (R&B) Odisha, Bhubaneswar on behalf of the Governor of Odisha invites percentage rate bids for E.I. works which are to be received through online bidding, double cover system as detailed in: <https://tendersorissa.gov.in>. The details of bid documents will be available in the above website from **dt.29.07.2026 at 05.00 P.M. to dt.13.08.2026 up to 05.00 P.M.** The bidders must possess compatible Digital Signature Certificate of Class II or III. Bids received online shall be opened **dt.14.08.2026 at 11.30 A.M.** in the Office of the Superintending Engineer, Electrical Circle (R&B) Odisha, Bhubaneswar. Further details can be seen from the e-procurement portal www.tendersorissa.gov.in. Addendum / Corrigendum, if required, will be available only in the Website.

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34001/516/2627

QIPR-34001/34006/126-27/0024

Sold your car? Ensure ownership transfer

COVERNOTE



One can't simply hand over the keys, collect the money and move on. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

K. Nityakalyani

Apparently, nightmares come in a few familiar forms: turning up unprepared for an examination, desperately trying to reach somewhere on time or you/ your loved ones being threatened, chased or attacked.

Receiving a court summons in a motor accident compensation case involving your vehicle. The one you sold five years ago.

Ok, that one may not feature in psychology textbooks. But it is certainly a nightmare you do not want to experience.

A relative of mine did. Almost. Last week, he received a traffic challan for a car he had sold years ago. Alarmed, he logged on to the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways' Parivahan portal, only to discover that the vehicle was still registered in his name. The buyer had never completed the transfer of the Registration Certificate (RC). That meant that legally my relative was still responsible for anything to do with the vehicle.

The discovery was enough to ruin his week. And mine. Because his next outreach was to me.

The mighty paperwork

There is an old saying: "It's not done till the paperwork is done". Nowhere is this truer than when selling a vehicle.

You cannot simply hand over the keys, the RC and the transfer forms, collect the money and move on. Until the ownership transfer is completed, you remain exposed.

Here is what should be done. Both buyer and seller must sign Forms 29 and 30 clearly mentioning the date of sale and each should retain an original. The buyer should clearly be named with address, mobile number and an identify proof. This fixes the timeframe for transfer and identifies the buyer.

Brokers many a time take over the vehicle claiming they are the buyers and then hunt for customers. That is why they will cajole you into signing blank forms. Please don't.

The seller, you, should send a letter to your RTO, saying you have sold the vehicle and disclaiming any further liability. Attach copies of Forms 29 and 30, the identify proof of the buyer and sale proof. Send it by Speed Post, preserve the receipt, track the delivery online and keep proof of delivery safely.

To be fair, my relative had done everything required. Except check if the actual transfer had taken place.

Not a first

Sadly, this is not an isolated case. I have heard several such stories. I have faced it myself.

One friend discovered that a vehicle he had long since sold had been implicated in an illegal drugs case. Imagine receiving notice in a fatal accident claim.

Point of sale formalities apart, the system itself needs improvement. Both buyer and seller should be able to track the ownership transfer online, and automatic alerts should be sent to them, and to the authorities, whenever a transfer remains incomplete beyond a reasonable period.

In an age of digital records, instant communication and online services, this is not too much to ask.

If the police can send us a traffic challan by SMS within seconds of a violation, surely our transport system can tell us when ownership of a vehicle worth several lakh rupees has not changed hands.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)



The lifecycle of an electronic gold receipt ends when the owner opts for physical delivery. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

What's behind the vault of India's gold exchange

Every electronic gold receipt has a story before it reaches your portfolio; a journey from physical gold through vaults, depositories and stock exchanges, it can change hands countless times

VAULT VOYAGE

Vaishali R Venkat

The life of every Electronic Gold Receipt (EGR) begins and ends with physical gold. Between these two points lies a carefully choreographed journey. Before an EGR lands in your demat account, physical gold must first pass through a tightly regulated ecosystem that verifies the metal, creates the receipt and enables trading on the exchange.

Why a gold exchange?

For decades, India's physical gold trade largely took place through jewellers, bullion dealers and over-the-counter transactions. While gold itself was standardised, trading remained fragmented. Despite accounting for a large share of global gold consumption, India lacked a nationwide exchange for trading standardised physical gold, with prices varying across markets/States.

The EGRs were introduced to bridge this gap. The Gold Exchange provides a national platform for trading standardised physical gold, facilitates transparent price discovery, improves liquidity and assures the quality of gold.

Creation of an EGR

The journey begins when the owner of eligible physical gold deposits it with a vault manager registered



The lifecycle of an EGR ends when the beneficial owner opts for physical delivery: the vault manager hands over the gold upon request

with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) for conversion into EGRs. Only eligible gold sourced through imports or exchange-accredited domestic refineries can be converted.

The gold is weighed, assayed and verified, after which the vault manager records the deposit in the common interface and no EGR can be created unless it is backed by the corresponding physical gold in the vault. The EGR is then credited to the beneficial owner's demat account and made tradeable on the stock exchange by the Depository. The vault manager and the Depository regularly reconcile EGR records with the underlying physical gold, while the Depository also conducts periodic inspections of the vaulted gold.

Trading of an EGR

The moment an EGR enters a demat account, it sheds the identity of the gold bar and begins a life of its own. Unlike physical gold, it can change hands countless times without a single gram moving out of the vault. Behind the scenes, the Depos-



If a dispute over the quality of the gold arises at the time of withdrawal, it is resolved through an empanelled assayer

itory keeps the exchanges and clearing corporations updated on newly created EGRs, while the clearing corporation ensures seamless settlement between the buyer and the seller.

Fungibility

Once an EGR is created, it is no longer tied to a particular gold bar. Instead, it represents a standard quantity and purity of gold. So, when an investor converts an EGR into physical gold, they receive gold of the same specifications, and not necessarily the very bar that was originally deposited. This feature, known as fungibility, works together with inter-operability, allowing investors, wherever possible, to collect their gold from a different eligible vault location instead of returning to the vault where it was originally deposited.

Conversion

The lifecycle of an EGR ends when the owner opts for physical delivery. On receiving the request through the Depository, the vault manager hands over the gold and simultaneously extinguishes the correspond-

ing EGR. The Depository then updates the stock exchanges and clearing corporations to keep their records in sync.

The EGR ecosystem

Unlike physical gold transactions that typically involve only a buyer and a seller, the EGR brings together multiple regulated entities. Vault managers safeguard the gold, Depositories maintain electronic ownership records, stock exchanges facilitate trading, clearing corporations settle transactions, brokers connect investors to the market, while eligible gold depositors create EGRs and investors trade.

Should EGRs be part of your portfolio?

EGRs are certainly not a replacement for jewellery. Whether they will emerge as a viable alternative to Gold ETFs remains to be seen. EGRs combine the convenience of trading electronically while retaining the option of taking physical delivery of gold.

Every new investment avenue attracts early enthusiasm. Before climbing onto the EGR bandwagon, investors should first understand the framework behind it. After all, informed investing begins with understanding the product. Knowledge must precede participation.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.35	7.40	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.10	7.10	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.00	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	8.00	7.00	8.00	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	8.00	6.00	7.50	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.10	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.80	7.25	7.25	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	8.10	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.50	6.25	6.50	6.50
Bandhan Bank	7.45	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.25	6.65	6.50	6.55
CSB Bank	7.35	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.85	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.50	6.90	7.00	7.50
Federal Bank	6.70	6.25	6.40	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.35	6.50	7.35	6.75
IndusInd Bank	7.00	6.75	7.00	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Jammu & Kashmir Bank				
7.30	6.80	6.80	6.85	
IDBI Bank				
6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25	
Karnataka Bank				
7.00	6.50	6.15	6.15	
Kotak Mahindra Bank				
6.80	6.35	6.40	6.25	
RBL Bank				
7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70	
SBM Bank India				
7.35	7.35	7.10	7.00	
South Indian Bank				
6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70	
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank				
7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70	
YES Bank				
7.25	6.65	7.00	6.75	
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda				
6.75	6.25	6.25	6.30	
Bank of India				
6.85	6.50	6.70	6.00	
Bank of Maharashtra				
6.65	6.40	5.25	5.00	
Canara Bank				
6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25	
Central Bank of India				
6.70	6.10	6.00	6.00	
Indian Bank				
6.80	6.10	6.05	6.00	
Indian Overseas Bank				
6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10	
Punjab National Bank				
6.60	6.25	6.30	6.35	
Punjab & Sind Bank				
6.85	5.85	5.85	5.95	
State Bank of India				
6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05	
Union Bank of India				
6.65	6.20	6.10	6.00	

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05	7.25-9.05
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60	7.15-9.60
Punjab National Bank	7.30-9.30	7.25-9.20	7.25-9.20
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
UCO Bank**	7.15-9.25	7.15-9.25	7.15-9.25
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
ICICI Bank	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.49-11.72	7.49-11.72	7.49-11.72
Federal Bank	8.35 - 10.257.35 - 10.25	7.35 - 9.25	

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank			
7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	
Bandhan Bank			
8.55 - 13.528.55 - 13.528.55 - 13.52			
RBL Bank			
8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #	
CSB Bank			
8.30 #	8.30 #	8.30 #	
HDFC Bank			
7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #	
City Union Bank			
8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50	
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance			
7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #	
Bajaj Housing Finance			
7.25 #	7.25 #	7.25 #	
Tata Capital			
8.00 #	8.00 #	8.00 #	
PNB Housing Finance			
7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #	
GIC Housing Finance			
8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #	
SMFG India Home Finance			
9.25 #	9.25 #	9.25 #	
Sammaan Capital			
8.75 #	8.75 #	8.75 #	
Aditya Birla Capital			
7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #	
ICICI Home Finance			
7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #	
Godrej Housing Finance			
7.65 #	7.65 #	7.65 #	
*Extra 0.05% rate concession to borrowers taking insurance			
**Additional concession of 0.05% & 0.10% for women borrowers and takeover loans, respectively			
#Onwards Rates as on July 22 Source:Paisabazaar.com			

How passionate are you about your collectibles?

THINKINVESTOR

We typically focus on what we have to give up when we sell the assets than the gains that we can generate by selling them

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Previously in this column, we discussed about passion assets. This refers to assets that are collectibles such as paintings and antiques. Passion assets are both consumption and investment assets. That is, you can enjoy them as collectibles and later sell the assets to generate gains. In this article, we discuss the risks associated with such assets, especially the pain of parting with them.

When we own a collectible, we typically focus on what we have to give-up when we sell the asset than the gains we can generate by selling them. This explains why we want a higher price when we sell an asset we own than if we want to buy the same asset when we do not own it. Behavioural psychologists refer to this as the endowment effect. Think of it as the pain premium. At the extreme, you may be unwilling to part with an asset even if the offer price is good. Unless you sell these assets, they are just personal collectibles, not passion assets. So, the primary risk is that you may never realize gains on such assets during your lifetime.

Fortunately, time is a beneficial factor. The longer you own an asset, the more willing you may be to part with it. You may be unwilling to sell your first collectible you acquired, say, 20 years ago and your recent acquisition. But you may be less reluctant to part with the ones you acquired, say, ten years ago. Sometimes, you may be willing to sell from your old collection when you acquire a similar asset with better provenance. Typically, a large collection of passion assets is sold when the legal heirs clear the estate of a collector. To ensure that your legal heirs eventually get good value for your passion assets, you must document each asset's provenance, whenever possible. This refers to dating the age of the asset, the date of acquisition, its price and the source of acquisition (a dealer or a private collector). Remember, narrative adds value to an asset. A 100-year rosewood barley-twist desk may fetch a significantly higher price if it were sourced from a colonial-era palace or from a well-known personality than from an unknown private home. Finally, you must ensure your assets are well-preserved. Direct sunlight can harm rare and vintage paintings. Managing these risks can enhance the value of your passion assets.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

ALL CLEAR

Gymnast Langton discharged from hospital after a nasty fall



REUTERS

England’s Gabriel Langton was discharged from hospital after scans revealed no lasting damage from a fall which temporarily halted the Commonwealth Games men’s team final in Glasgow. Langton landed awkwardly, head first, off the high bar in the final apparatus of Friday’s final. The competition was held up for 20 minutes.

PROUD SKIPPER

‘The young bunch of players have been showing tremendous energy’



BCCI

India captain Shreyas Iyer described his maiden T20I series win as skipper as a “special moment.” “They are a young bunch of players who have been showing tremendous energy on the field. To have such kind of energy is what I require as a captain,” said Shreyas after India regained the top spot in the ICC T20I rankings.

ELITE LIST

Pogacar bags a record-equalling fifth Tour de France title



AFF

Tadej Pogacar clinched a record-equalling fifth Tour de France title on Sunday after safely completing the final stage, won by Mathieu van der Poel. The Slovenian joins Jacques Anquetil, Eddy Merckx, Bernard Hinault and Miguel Indurain in an elite list. It was the 27-year-old Pogacar’s third straight triumph.

FIGHTING KNOCKS

Hodge, Hope help West Indies post 311 in the first innings



AFF

Skipper Shai Hope’s 92 and a knock of 84 by Kavem Hodge helped West Indies make 311 in the first innings against Pakistan on the second day of the first Test at Tarouba in Trinidad on Sunday. **The scores:** West Indies 311 in 98.5 overs (Hodge 84, Hope 92, Mohammed Ali 4/50) vs Pakistan. **Toss:** West Indies.

Mirabai completes a hat-trick of gold as records tumble

The Indian weightlifting star rules the roost in women’s 48kg; another Manipuri, Rishikanta, bags silver in men’s 60kg

CWEALTH GAMES

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

As a glowing Mirabai Chanu walked into the mixed zone to meet the Indian media here on Sunday, she was in high spirits. So much so that when the cameramen bent down on their knees to fix their microphones, she smiled and said: “*Mera Aashirwad* (My blessings)! Please finish quickly as I have not eaten for the last few days!”

Mirabai was the darling of the packed gathering at the Scottish Event Campus during the Games.

Going for her third successive Commonwealth Games gold medal, the 31-year-old Indian weightlifting star broke records in both snatch and clean and jerk with ease.

Huge cheer

The gathering gave her a rousing reception after she completed her lifts and secured gold in women’s 48kg with a record 190kg (85 & 105).

“I am very happy that I was able to get my third gold for India,” she said.

Mirabai revealed that



All smiles: Mirabai triumphed with ease while Rishikanta overcame knee pain to finish second. ANI & PTI

there was a lot of pressure on her and she was delighted to handle it. “A lot was going on in my mind –

whether I would be able to win the medal this time. I am relieved,” she said. Mirabai added that maintain-

ing the 48kg category had been a difficult task. “This performance is very important for me because I

have been controlling my body weight for a long time. It was very difficult for me to bring it down to 48kg. From now on, I will focus on the Asian Games.”

It was an emotional moment for another Manipuri weightlifter Rishikanta Singh Chanambam, too. Winning a medal was a “dream-come-true” for the 28-year-old as he claimed silver in men’s 60kg with a total of 264kg (a Games record 121kg in snatch and 143 in clean and jerk).

“It’s a dream to win my first Commonwealth medal. My family will be very happy,” said Rishikanta. He is the first male weightlifter from the State to win a medal at the Games.

Other Indian results:

Boxing: Women: 54kg: Preeti Panwar bt Deborah Mtenje (Maw) RSC, enters quarterfinals; **Men: 55kg:** Jadumani Singh bt Sumama Rehman (Pak) 5-0, makes it to last eight.

Lawn bowls: Women’s pairs: Pinki Singh & Rupa Rani Tirkey lost to Amy Pharaoh & Sian Honnor (Eng) in tie-break; Pinki & Rupa lost to Amanda Steenkamp & Diana Viljoen (Nam) in tie-break; **Men:** Putul Sonowal lost to Shaun James (Mlt) 0.5-1.5.

Swimming: Men’s 4x200m freestyle relay team (Dhakshan Shashikumar, Aneesh Gowda, Aryan Nehra and Srihari Nataraj), qualified for final.



Charged up: Neeraj is eyeing his second gold at CWG. PTI

ha, Neeraj said he has worked on his fitness and technique. “I have worked on my weaknesses and on my fitness. I feel much better now,” he said.

Neeraj admitted that the weather conditions would be challenging but insisted they were the same for everyone and that athletes simply had to adjust.

“Yes, I was training the other day. The conditions are tough, but they are the same for everyone. No matter how bad the conditions are, we have to stay mentally strong. I will have to give my 100 per cent,” he said.

Javelin throw has become intensely competitive in South Asia, with fel-

low Indians Rohit Yadav and Yashvir Singh, Pakistan’s Arshad Nadeem and Sri Lanka’s Ramesh Tharanga Pathirage in the fray. Neeraj said it’s a welcome rivalry.

“When the competition is tough, we are able to push each other more. That’s a good thing, especially as there is a lot of competition in South Asia,” he said.

Neeraj appears ready for the challenge, and the men’s javelin throw on July 30 and 31 could well provide an indication of his current form and the direction his career is taking.

The athletics event will begin at the Scotstoun Stadium on Monday.

Sooryavanshi sparkles in India’s clean sweep against Zimbabwe

INDIA IN ZIMBABWE

Agence France-Presse
HARARE

Teenage sensation Vaibhav Sooryavanshi scored his second half-century in four days as India beat Zimbabwe by 35 runs on Sunday for a 3-0 Twenty20 International series sweep.

India won the toss and posted 192 for five at the Harare Sports Club, led by a quickfire 81 from Sooryavanshi. He faced 49 balls and hit eight fours and four sixes.

Zimbabwe reached 157 for seven in reply, thanks mainly to an unbeaten 54 from lower-order batter Ryan Burl (43b, 5x4).

Victory marked an Indian turnaround after a 2-0 T20I series loss in Ireland and a 4-0 drubbing in England. It was the second straight series loss for Zimbabwe after going down 2-1 to Bangladesh.

The 15-year-old Sooryavanshi has had a memorable tour of Zimbabwe. He scored his maiden T20I half-century off just 18 balls in the first match and followed it up with 20 off nine deliveries in the second.

The left-hander made

his intentions clear from the first ball. He launched the Indian innings with a four off Zimbabwe captain and all-rounder Sikandar Raza and reached 50 off 31 balls. He fell off the final ball of the 15th over. Sooryavanshi got out to Wessly Madhevere when Brad Evans dashed from the ropes to long off and caught the ball.

Zimbabwe slumped to 65 for four in reply with opener Brian Bennett and Raza both dismissed for golden ducks. The highlight of the innings was the 60-run fifth-wicket stand between Burl and Madhevere (28).

SCOREBOARD

INDIA
Vaibhav Sooryavanshi c Evans b Madhevere 81 (49b, 8x4, 4x6), Abhishek Sharma c Marumani b Muzarabani 2 (4b), Ishan Kishan b Sikandar 29 (26b, 4x4), Shreyas Iyer c Madhevere b Evans 27 (18b, 2x4), Tilak Varma (not out) 11 (9b, 1x4), Rinku Singh c Madhevere b Evans 25 (14b, 2x4, 1x6); Extras (b-1, lb-1, w-15); 17; Total (for five wkts. in 20 overs): 192.
FALL OF WICKETS
1-20 (Abhishek, 1.5 overs), 2-95 (Kishan, 10.1), 3-145 (Sooryavanshi, 14.6), 4-164 (Shreyas, 17.1), 5-192 (Rinku, 19.6).



Take that! Sooryavanshi gave another exhibition of his prodigious talent. BCCI

ZIMBABWE BOWLING
Sikandar 4-0-40-1, Muzarabani 4-0-33-1, Nyamhuri 2-0-18-0, Evans 4-0-41-2, Masakadza 1-0-14-0, Madhevere 4-0-37-1, Bennett 1-0-7-0.
ZIMBABWE
Brian Bennett c Sooryavanshi b Mayank 0 (1b), Ben Curran c Mayank b Bishnoi 20 (19b, 2x4), Dion Myers c Shreyas b Yash Thakur 19 (15b, 1x4, 1x6), Sikandar Raza c & b Yash Thakur 0 (1b), Ryan Burl (not out) 54 (43b, 5x4), Wessly Madhevere c Tilak b Mayank 28 (25b, 1x4, 2x6), Tadiwanashe Marumani b Ashok 1 (3b), Brad Evans c Rinku b

Mayank 14 (13b, 1x6), Newman Nyamhuri (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (b-4, lb-2, nb-1, w-13); 20; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 157.
FALL OF WICKETS
1-0 (Bennett, 0.1), 2-34 (Myers, 3.4), 3-34 (Sikandar, 3.5), 4-65 (Curran, 7.2), 5-125 (Madhevere, 15.4), 6-134 (Marumani, 17.1), 7-156 (Evans, 19.5).
INDIA BOWLING
Mayank 4-0-29-3, Yash Thakur 4-0-45-2, Ashok 4-0-20-1, Bishnoi 4-0-24-1, Shedge 2-0-15-0, Abhishek 2-0-18-0.
Toss: India; PoM & PoS: Sooryavanshi; <i>India won by 35 runs to clinch series 3-0.</i>

U Mumba’s UTT reign continues

Amol Karhadkar
PANAJI

Defending champion U Mumba TT snapped Dempo Goa Challengers’ unbeaten run to retain the Ultimate Table Tennis crown with a 8-5 victory in the Season-7 final at the Dr. Shyama Prasad Mukherjee Indoor Stadium on Sunday.

The summit clash ebbed and flowed before U Mumba’s superior depth and composure proved decisive.

Goa made a bright start through teenager P.B. Abhinandh, who unsettled Frenchman Lilian Bardet once again with his unconventional style built around a long-pimpled backhand rubber. Although he couldn’t replicate his 3-0 demolition from the tournament opener, Abhinandh repeatedly disrupted the Frenchman’s rhythm before Bardet finally found his range with a flurry of forehand winners in the third game to put U Mumba on the board.

World No.24 Bernadette Szocs then showcased why she remains one of the world’s elite. Locked in a high-quality contest against World No. 34 Anna Hurshey, she trailed 4-6 after dropping the opening game before reeling off six



On cloud nine: The U Mumba players and staff exult after going the distance. BUTTERFLY UTT

consecutive points to wrest control and restore Goa’s advantage.

Leading 4-2 after two singles, Challengers looked set to tighten the grip. Instead, Manush Shah changed the complexion of the final. The bespectacled Indian combined superbly with Hurshey to blank Alvaro Robles and Syndrela Das in mixed doubles, silencing a partisan crowd of over 1,200 and drawing U Mumba level.

The all-left-hander duel between Manush and Robles lived up to expectations, with both players producing breathtaking forehand and backhand top-spin exchanges.

The rally of the evening came at 6-6 in the opening

game, Robles finishing a 13-shot exchange with a stunning forehand sidespin winner from well behind the table before stringing together four straight points to take the game.

Manush responded in style. Trailing 9-10 in the second, he produced a full-stretch forehand topspin winner to force a golden point, where Robles missed an ambitious third-ball attack. Buoyed by the escape, Manush quickened the tempo in the decider, forcing a string of unforced errors to put U Mumba on the verge.

With U Mumba leading 7-5 and needing only one more game, Anusha Kutumbale, preferred ahead of Nithyashree Mani, kept

her composure against teen sensation Syndrela Das. While Syndrela was forced into an all-out attacking approach in pursuit of three straight games, Anusha played percentage table tennis throughout. Syndrela saved two championship points to force a golden point but miscued a high ball, handing U Mumba the top prize.

The result: Final: U Mumba TT bt Dempo Goa Challengers 8-5 (Lilian Bardet lost to P. B. Abhinandh 7-11, 9-11, 11-6; Anna Hurshey lost to Bernadette Szocs 11-5, 7-11, 7-11; Manush Shah & Hurshey bt Alvaro Robles & Syndrela Das 11-8, 11-7, 11-9; Manush bt Robles 6-11, 11-10, 11-5; Anusha Kutumbale bt Syndrela Das 11-10).

INBRIEF



Indian men bag youth Asian title, women settle for silver

The Indian sub-junior men's team defeated Pakistan 3-1 in the gold medal match of the FIH Youth Hockey5s Asian Championship in Muscat. In women's competition, India settled for silver after a 2-4 loss in the final against China. Earlier, India booked its place in the summit clash with a 8-1 victory over Kazakhstan in the semifinal.

The results (final): Men: India 3 (Romit Pal 5, Ketan Kushwaha 12, Shahrukh Ali 13) bt Pakistan (Muhammad Usman 16).
Women: China 4 (Tongtong Lu 1, Kexin Tang 5, Jiaxin Guo 6, Chen Ge 19) bt India 2 (Nousheen Naz 13, Pushpa Manjhi 20).

Indian winger Manisha joins Greek club AEK Athens

Indian women's football team winger Manisha Kalyan on Saturday signed for Greek top-division side AEK Athens. She has made the move from Peruvian side Alianza Lima Femenino. After playing for Sethu FC and Gokulam Kerala FC in the Indian Women's League, Manisha joined Cypriot club Apollon Ladies FC in 2022. Manisha has been a mainstay in the national side since her debut in 2019.

Kush Maini finishes second in Hungary

Kush Maini finished second in Sunday's FIA Formula 2 feature race at the Hungaroring in Hungary, securing his third podium of the 2026 season after an ill-timed Virtual Safety Car compromised his chances of victory.



Washington to miss first Test against Sri Lanka

Spin bowling all-rounder Washington Sundar is unavailable for the first Test against Sri Lanka starting on August 15 while injured all-rounder Nitish Kumar and fast bowler Harshit Rana are unlikely to be part of the Indian squad for the two-match series. India will tour Sri Lanka next month with the first Test to be played from August 15-19 at Galle, followed by the second at Colombo (SSC) from August 23-27. According to a BCCI source, Washington's availability for the second Test is subject to fitness. Sai Sudharsan's availability is also subject to fitness.

Raynier's hat-trick powers JFC to easy win

Sports Bureau

Jamshedpur FC began its Durand Cup campaign by crushing Sri Lankan Armed Forces side Defenders FC 5-0 in the Group C clash in Ranchi on Sunday. Debutant Raynier Fernandes starred with a brilliant hat-trick, while Aman C.K. and Devendra Murganekar scored one goal each during the Red Miners' rout.

Coached by Kaizad Ambapardiwalla, Jamshedpur dominated from the outset, with Raynier netting twice inside the opening 10 minutes.

Aman and Devendra added to the tally before half-time as Jamshedpur took a 4-0 lead heading into the break.

The results: Group C: Jamshedpur 5 (Raynier Fernandes 4, 6, 82, Aman C.K. 23, Devendra Murganekar 39) bt Defenders 0.

At Kolkata: Group B: Indian Army 1 (Christopher Kamei 47) bt Samaleswari Sporting 0.

How champ Anahat broke a 'curse'

The 18-year-old becomes the first Indian to win the World junior title; hopes her triumph will be a game-changer for Indian squash

Sports Bureau

It was a case of now or never for Anahat Singh.

After multiple unsuccessful attempts, the supremely talented 18-year-old had one last crack at the World junior squash women's title. And things finally fell into place in Ontario as Anahat carved her own piece of history by becoming the first Indian to hoist the individual prize.

The 'teen titan' was both delighted and relieved to break the "curse".

"I still feel like I am dreaming. It (crown) means the world to me," Anahat said after cruising past Ruqayya Salem of Egypt 11-3, 11-7, 11-9.

"This is the biggest event a junior can play in. I have been playing in it for four years, and it has not gone my way (lost in the semis and quarters). If someone asked, I always said: 'This tournament is a curse.' But coming into the event, I knew that it was my last year in juniors and that I had to give my 100%. I am really glad that it worked out," added Anahat, the force which put a halt to Egypt's sustained dominance in women's category.



Historic win: Anahat cruised past her Egyptian opponent in the title decider. WORLD SQUASH

The Delhi girl, who lived up to the top billing in the global competition, revealed that she played with a clear mind in the final.

"I knew that I would play terribly if I stressed myself, so I just came on court and hit my lines well. I wanted to enjoy every moment of a World championship final."

Anahat, ranked World

No. 20 at the senior level, hoped that her triumph in World juniors would be a game-changer for Indian squash. "If a few people watch my matches and the matches of other players in the event, we will gain a lot more recognition. India is a huge country, so if it reaches the right audience, squash can rapidly grow as a sport".

TNPL organisers promise better pitches and exciting contests in the 10th edition

CRICKET

Sports Bureau
CHENNAI

As the TNPL gears up for a milestone season this year with the 10th edition set to begin on August 4 in Dindigul, the organisers have promised better pitches to ensure the action on the field is exciting.

Unearthing talent

The TNPL has helped unearth promising talents from the State to play for IPL franchises and even the country, with T. Natarajan, Varun Chakravarthy and B. Sai Sudharsan among a few.

However, in recent



Ready to roll: TNCA president T.J. Srinivasaraj and secretary U. Bhagwandas Rao with dignitaries at the TNPL launch. R. RAGU

times, that pipeline has started to dry out a bit, and one reason has been that the low-scoring pitches in the TNPL have not helped batters show their wares at a time when competition from other states has

increased.

TNCA president T.J. Srinivasaraj said that the second half of the season to be played in Chennai will help in this regard.

The ability to rotate between three to four surfaces

Norris grabs first race win of the season in Hungary

FORMULA ONE

Agence France-Presse
BUDAPEST

Lando Norris won the Hungarian Grand Prix on Sunday ahead of Max Verstappen, while championship leader Kimi Antonelli recovered from a pre-race penalty to complete the podium in third.

Starting from pole position, Norris lost the lead to McLaren teammate Oscar Piastri on the opening lap but fought his way back to the front to secure his first race victory of the season.

McLaren's hopes of a one-two finish were dashed with 15 laps remaining when Piastri retired with a gearbox problem while running second behind Norris.

Norris, the reigning world champion, won at the Hungaroring for the second successive year as he became the fifth different race winner in the last five Grands Prix.

Norris triumphed in the sprint race in Miami in May but had not taken the chequered flag at a Grand Prix since Sao Paulo last November.

Verstappen matched his best result of the season despite a difficult weekend for Red Bull.

Antonelli increased his lead at the top of the stand-



Long wait ends: Norris gets up close and personal with his winner's trophy. AFP

ings to 50 points over Lewis Hamilton after moving up from seventh on the starting grid.

Hamilton slid from fourth to fifth in the race after receiving a five-second penalty for speeding in the pit lane, dropping him behind Ferrari teammate Charles Leclerc.

The season now heads into its summer break before resuming with the Dutch Grand Prix at Zandvoort on August 23.

Malaysia steps in

The Bahrain Grand Prix, which was cancelled in April due to the Middle East war, will be held in Malaysia in early October, Formula One and the International Automobile Federation (FIA) announced on Sunday.

The results (70/70 laps): 1. Lando Norris (McLaren) 1hr 39min 56.180sec; 2. Max Verstappen (Red Bull) + 15.080s; 3. Kimi Antonelli (Mercedes) 18.728; 4. Charles Leclerc (Ferrari) 23.840; 5. Lewis Hamilton (Ferrari) 24.540; 6. Isack Hadjar (Red Bull) 55.488; 7. George Russell (Mercedes) 57.503. +1 lap: 8. Liam Lawson (Racing Bulls); 9. Nico Hulkenberg (Audi); 10. Arvid Lindblad (Racing Bulls); 11. Gabriel Bortoleto (Audi); 12. Pierre Gasly (Alpine); 13. Lance Stroll (Aston Martin); 14. Fernando Alonso (Aston Martin); +2 laps: 15. Franco Colapinto (Alpine); 16. Esteban Ocon (Haas); 17. Alexander Albon (Williams); 18. Carlos Sainz (Williams); 19. Oliver Bearman (Haas).
DNF: Oscar Piastri (McLaren); Sergio Perez (Cadillac); Valtteri Bottas (Cadillac).
Standings: Drivers: 1. Antonelli 219; 2. Hamilton 169; 3. Norris 160; 4. Leclerc 138; 5. Russell 128
Constructors: 1. Mercedes 379; 2. Ferrari 307; 3. McLaren 220; 4. Red Bull 177; 5. Racing Bulls 66.

AROUND THE CITY

New India Assurance clinches T20 title

New India Assurance (NIA) defeated United India Insurance (UII) by 10 runs in the final of the Public Sector General Insurance Companies T20 tournament on Sunday. Chasing a target of 96, UII was bowled out for 85 in the 19th over.

The scores: NIA 95/8 in 20 overs (S.S. Sharath 3/12) bt UII 85 in 18.4 overs (D. Abhishekh 4/19, S. Lokith 3/6, R.R. Senthilkumar 3/13).

Special awards:
Player of the final & tournament: S. Lokith (NIA);
Best batter: R.R. Senthilkumar (NIA).
Best bowler: D. Abhishekh (NIA).

Chess tournament for school students

Modern Senior Secondary School will conduct the

15th International rating chess tournament (for school students only), under the aegis of the AICF, TNSCA & CGDCA, from August 1 to 4 on its premises. The last date for registration is Tuesday. For further details, contact Sripriya Rajarajan 044 22240110, S. Ellammal 70103 13858, H. Santhanam 98405 83157 and R. Yamuna 90436 90467.

LIVE TELECAST

CWG 2026: Day 4, Sony Sports Ten 2 & LIV, 1 p.m.

Durand Cup: Sony Sports Ten 5 & LIV, 7.30 p.m.

West Indies vs Pakistan: First Test, Day 3, FanCode, 7.30 p.m.

One N Only should make amends

HYDERABAD: The five-year-old gelding One N Only, who ran second in his last start should make amends in the Anab E Shahi Plate, the chief event of the opening day's races of the Hyderabad Monsoon Races 2026, here on Monday (July 27) afternoon.

1 ADILABAD PLATE (Div. I) (1,100m), (Terms) Maiden, 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 1.10 pm: 1. Ashwa Vivegam (11) Gaurav 56, 2. Ojas Maximus (1) A.A. Vikrant 56, 3. Yali (3) Trevor 56, 4. Ashwa Jaffna (10) B. Nikhil 54.5, 5. Belgium Waffle (9) Mohit 54.5, 6. Evan Sville (6) P. Sai K 54.5, 7. Gacchan-manasvin (4) Md. Ismail 54.5, 8. Love In Paris (7) R.S. Jodha 54.5, 9. Miss Lovely Angel (13) Rafique Sk. 54.5, 10. N R I Sunpower (8) B.R. Kumar 54.5, 11. Speedy Queen (2) Akshay K 54.5, 12. Star Lit (12) G. Naresh 54.5 and 13. Trend Setter (5) Abhay Singh 54.5.
1. YALI, 2. SPEEDY QUEEN, 3. MISS LOVELY ANGEL.

2 CON AMORE PLATE (Div. II) (1,400m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II), 1.40: 1. Ragnarök (9) Shivam 60, 2. Silver Act (7) P. Sai K 59, 3. Perception (3) G. Naresh 58.5, 4. Arabeska (5) Akshay K 57, 5. Detective (4) Gaurav 57, 6. Annhilator (1) Kuldeep Sr. 56, 7. Romantic Grey (2) A.A. Vikrant 55, 8. Knight Crusader (8) B.R. Kumar 54.5, 9. Exclusive Black (10) Md. Ekram 54 and 10. Star Forever (6) Ajay K 53.
1. PERCEPTION, 2. ARABESKA, 3. KNIGHT CRUSADER

3 ADILABAD PLATE (Div. II) (1,100m), (Terms) Maiden, 3-y-o only (Cat. II), 2.10: 1. My Way My Rules (10) Akshay K 56, 2. Rajendra (12) V. Bunde 56, 3. You Tuber (8) Md. Ekram 56, 4. Bay-one (7) G. Naresh 54.5, 5. Calista Babe (9) Gaurav 54.5, 6. First Kiss (4) Kuldeep Sr. 54.5, 7. Khamagani (1) B. Nikhil 54.5, 8. Menlo Park (3) P. Sai K 54.5, 9. N R I Crypto Power (11) A.A. Vikrant 54.5, 10. Queen Eternal (6) B.R. Kumar 54.5, 11. Trishika (2) Rafique Sk. 54.5 and 12. Veera's Lakshmi (5) Santosh Raj 54.5.
1. QUEEN ETERNAL, 2. YOU TUBER 3. MENLO PARK

4 CON AMORE PLATE (Div. I) (1,400m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 60 to 85 (Cat. II), 2.45: 1. Sugar (3) Akshay K 57.5, 3. Certanity (4) Kuldeep Sr. 57, 4. Hurricane Bay (10) Rafique Sk. 56, 5. Azrinaz (1) A.A. Vikrant 55.5, 6. Secret Saint (7) Trevor 55, 7. Bhairava (9) P. Ajeeth K 53, 8. Noble Heart (5) Shivam 53, 9. Knight Regent (8) P. Sai K 51.5 and 10. White Pearl (6) Md. Ekram 50.5.
1. SUGAR, 2. SECRET SAINT, 3. DECOY

5 BASARA TROPHY (1,400m), 3-y-o and upward, 20 to 45 (Cat. III), 3.20: 1. Knotty Senorita (16) Md. Ekram 61.5, 2. Bold Beauty (5) Santosh Raj 60.5, 3. Great Giver (3) R.S. Jodha 60.5, 4. Gold Touch (7) Kuldeep Sr. 59.5, 5. Real Thalavva (12) Mohit 59.5, 6. Cherish The Lady (10) Ajay K 58.5, 7. Quattro (9) B.R. Kumar 58.5, 8. Buddy (11) Akahay K 58, 9. Garfunkle (8) Trevor 58, 10. Winning Attitude (4) Rafique Sk. 57, 11. Aquatone (1) A.A. Vikrant 55, 12. Sadiya (4) P. Ajeeth K 54.5, 13. Silver Arrow (13) Abhay Singh 54.5, 14. Windsor (2) Surya Prakash 54, 15. American Gangster (6) G. Naresh 50 and 16. Caraxes (15) Kuldeep Jr. 50.
1. GARFUNKLE, 2. BUDDY, 3. CHERISH THE LADY

6 SALAR JUNG TROPHY (1,200m), 3-y-o and upward, rated 40 to 65 (Cat. II), 3.55: 1. Pacific Heights (4) P. Sai K 62, 2. Shadow Fax (5) A.A. Vikrant 61, 3. Warwick (6) G. Naresh 59.5, 4. Catchme If You Can (1) B. Nikhil 58.5, 5. Emerald Touch (11) Ashad Asbar 58, 6. Authoritarian (15) Gaurav 56.5, 7. Federer (8) Mohit 56.5, 8. Sharanga (12) Trevor 56.5, 9. Dontblackmyway (7) Rafique Sk. 55.5, 10. Calabasas (13) Ajay K

at the MAC Stadium should ensure that the pitches don't become tired as the tournament progresses.

Batters' game

"The T20 format has become more of a batters' game, and this year we will ensure we give batting-friendly pitches so that we see some high-scoring games," he remarked.

Ticket prices

Meanwhile, the ticket price for the matches in Dindigul has been set at ₹200 for all stands.

In Chennai, ticket prices will range from ₹100 (C, D, E, F, I, J, K Lower), ₹150 (C, D, E, F, G, H, I, J, K Upper) to ₹300 (KMK Terrace) and ₹500 (KMK Lower).

Alfonsine wins the main event

BENGALURU: Mr. P. Arun Kumar's Alfonsine (Yash up) won the Karnataka Mile Championship Cup (1,600m), the chief event of the races held here on Sunday (July 26). The winner is trained by S. John.

1. ESQUIRE PLATE (DIV. II), 1,200M: ACT OF KINDNESS (Trevor) I, Darringer (Arvind K) 2, Sindoor (Antony) 3 and Spark Of Life (Yash) 4, 3-3/4, 3-1/2 and Lnk. Im 13.108. Rs. 13 (w), 11, 16 and 15 (p), SHP: 39, THP: 42, FP: 66, Q: 60, Trinella: 152/116, Exacta: 413/166. Favourite: Act Of Kindness.

OWNERS: Villoo Poonawalla Racing & Breeding Pvt Ltd, M/s. DT Racing & Breeding LLP, Mr. Atul Ishwardas Chordia, Mr. Kairus Shavak Dadachanji, Mr. Munchi P. Shroff & Mr. S.R. Sanas. **Trainer:** Prasanna Kumar.

2. LUMBINI STUD PLATE (DIV. II), 1200M: VALIANT STREAM (Akshay K) 1, Joondalup (Aleemuddin) 2, Small Dreams (A. Hangal) 3 and Zephyrine (Pavan) 4, 5-1/2, Nk and 1. Im 12.31s. Rs. 16 (w), 11, 33 and 20 (p), SHP: 75, THP: 34, FP: 152, Q: 29, Trinella: 1,065/525, Exacta: 7,129/2,673. Favourite: Valiant Stream.

OWNERS: Manjiri Horse Breeders Farm Pvt Ltd, M/s. DT Racing & Breeding LLP & Stride Livestock Pvt Ltd. **Trainer:** S. Attallaahi.

OWNERS: Mr. H.K. Lakshman Gowda, Mr. Sharath M. Narayana & Mr. V. Lokanath. **Trainer:** V. Lokanath.

5. KARNATAKA MILE CHAMPIONSHIP CUP (1,600M): ALFONSINE (Yash) 1, Mayne Magic (Antony) 2, Nonpariel (Mukesh K) 3 and Galadbad (Akshay K) 4, 1-1/4, Nk and 4-1/2. Im 35.44s. Rs. 22 (w), 13, 10 and 32 (p), SHP: 34, THP: 52, FP: 41, Q: 22, Trinella: 295/351, Exacta: 16,889/9,651. Favourite: John Wick.

OWNER: Mr. P. Arun Kumar. **Trainer:** S. John.

6. SALAZAR PLATE (1,200M): AQUASTIC (Akshay K) 1, Stellantis (Trevor) 2, N R I Ace (Neeraj) 3 and Rodney (Pavan) 4. Not run: Felisa, 3, 2 and Nose. Im 11.26s. Rs. 38 (w), 16, 16 and 24 (p), SHP: 50, THP: 69, FP: 395, Q: 349, Trinella: 3,174/1,569, Exacta: 16,889/9,651. Favourite: John Wick.

OWNER: Mr. S. Pathy. **Trainer:** S. Attallaahi.

P.K. Ajith Kumar

Sophie Devine stopped kindly for her fans. She smiled into the selfie camera. She engaged for a while with the cricket fans, who had assembled in large numbers on that warm Sunday afternoon at Lord's for the Women's T20 World Cup match between India and Australia.

Devine's World Cup had been over by then: New Zealand had been knocked out of the Women's T20 World Cup.

She had announced that she would be quitting international cricket after the World Cup. Suzie Bates and Lea Tahuu, who along with Devine were the members of the New Zealand that won the last T20 World Cup in UAE two years ago, had also played their last matches for White Ferns.

It was as if these magnificent women, who between them played 894 games for New Zealand, were making the opening statement for what would be a summer of farewells in cricket. Their countryman Kane Williamson ended his international career during the Test series in England, which overlapped with the Women's World Cup. And there were more to follow: Ben Stokes, Heather Knight, Tammy Beaumont.

Rarely has cricket seen so many stars leaving the stage within a space of so little time. We also saw the curtain coming down on two high-profile coaching stints: of Brendon McCullum and Stephen Fleming. As if all that wasn't enough, Garry Sobers, cricket's greatest all-rounder of all time, bid an even more poignant farewell.

Devine, a quality all-rounder, has been one of the most feared batters in women's cricket. Those who watched her make 99 off just 36 balls for Royal Challengers Bengaluru against Gujarat Titans at the Brabourne Stadium in the inaugural Women's Premier League in 2023 were fortunate. It was the McCullum moment of the WPL. And McCullum, whose stunning hundred for Kolkata Knight Riders against RCB in the first ever match of the IPL set the tone for the world's most glamorous cricket league, had been the biggest influence on her, she had told this correspondent in an interview.

Sense of humour, and purpose

International women's cricket will certainly miss those big hits from Devine. Her sense of humour will be missed as much. Her interviews and press conferences have been fun.

After her sensational innings against KKR, when Devine was asked about her going after Australian all-rounder Ashleigh Gardner (24 runs in the second over of the innings), she smiled: "She has been a bully to a lot of other people over the years and I think it is only fair that she has got a bit of her own back."

Like Gardner, many bowlers have been at the receiving end of the might of Devine's bat over the last decade and a half, during which she scored 8096 runs and 241 wickets for New Zealand.

In 2020, she became the first player - man or woman - to hit six fifty-plus scores in T20Is. She had also represented New Zealand in hockey.

Bates had made her debut for New Zealand seven months before Devine. She too was a double international, having played basketball for her country. She, in fact, represented New Zealand at the 2008 Olympics in Beijing.

Bates has finished her international career with 4758 runs in T20Is, more than any other batter, male or female. She also scored 5982 runs in ODIs, with 13 hundreds. But it hadn't been easy for her, like other players of her generation, when women's cricket wasn't anywhere near as popular as it is today.

"When I was young, from 18 to 24, I studied, and we got grants from the government to study and play sports to help pay for our living allowance," Bates had once said in an interview to *The Hindu*. "I took part-time roles like coaching, whether it was basketball, cricket, to earn a little bit of money on the side, and when we were away, we got reimbursed."

If things are much easier for the women cricketers of today, they owe it to players like Bates, Devine and Tahuu, the seamer who finished her international career with 225 wickets for New Zealand.

Remarkable transformation

Knight and Beaumont, too, have been fortunate that they could be part of the remarkable transformation the game has undergone since they debuted for England. Women's cricket has changed so much that Knight could see her own image staring at her from all over London - at tube and bus stations and at Lord's - this English summer, thanks to the MCC's catchy campaign to promote the historic England-India Women's Test.

She and Beaumont were indeed lucky that they could end their international careers with the first ever Test match for women at Lord's. That was the 15th Test for Knight, who played 160 ODIs and 145 T20Is. She had led England to the 2017 World Cup victory at home. She was a

Cricket's summer of goodbyes

Rarely has the sport seen so many stars leaving the stage within a space of so little time. We also saw the curtain coming down on two high-profile coaching stints: of Brendon McCullum and Stephen Fleming. As if all that wasn't enough, Garry Sobers, cricket's greatest all-rounder of all-time, bid an even more poignant farewell



Signing off: Devine, Tahuu, Bates, McCullum, Stokes, Williamson, Fleming, Beaumont and Knight. GETTY IMAGES & K. MURALI KUMAR

batter that England could bank on.

Runs flowed freely from Beaumont's bat too, during her 17-year career, in which she scored 12 hundreds and 24 fifties in ODIs. She also became the first ever woman to score a Test double hundred.

If England's women's team lost two of their best batters, the men's team had to say goodbye to its inspiring captain, all-rounder extraordinaire and miracle-worker. Stokes is easily one of the most gifted cricketers of his generation and will go down in history as one of the game's all-time greats. With two incredible innings in 2019, he won England a World Cup and an Ashes Test victory for ages.

He was also the ideal captain to implement McCullum's brave ideas to transform England's Test fortunes. While the verdict on Bazball may not be unanimous, the fact remains that Stokes and McCullum brought a new dimension to Test match cricket.

The complete package

Stokes will be remembered as one of the most complete cricketers: he was brilliant as a batter, bowler and fielder. Yes, his career was hampered by injuries and a few incidents outside the field that he may not like to remember. But, few cricketers in our time have given the game as many exciting moments on the field. Williamson has undoubtedly been one of the greatest batters of his generation, a part of the Fab Four alongside Joe Root, Steve Smith and Virat Kohli. He was fabulous across formats. He finished his international career with 9515 runs in Tests at an average of 54.06, 7256

in ODIs at 48.69, 2575 in T20Is at 33.44. And he hit 48 international hundreds.

He also led New Zealand admirably. Fittingly, he was the captain when the Kiwis won the inaugural World Test Championship, after beating India in the final. He has been admired not just for being a run-machine, but for his genial nature as well.

It was from McCullum that Williamson had taken over the New Zealand captaincy. That was in 2016. Some three years later, McCullum turned to coaching with Trinbago Knight Riders and Kolkata Knight Riders.

Then in 2022, he was appointed as England's coach. That would prove to be perhaps the most discussed coaching job in cricket's history. McCullum's ultra-aggressive approach to playing Test cricket, called Bazball, gave England some great Test wins, but some chastening defeats too. Bazball had begun on a stunning note, with England notching up four magnificent against in a row at home - three against New Zealand and one against India. Some of the innings the England batters played, under McCullum, by the likes of Jonny Bairstow, Ollie Pope and Ben Duckett, were spectacular.

Sport's greatest theatre

But Test cricket is no extension of T20 cricket. It is sport's greatest theatre, and the most challenging mode of all sports. That is why we all love it.

You cannot Bazball your way out of trouble all the time. It was bound to fail at some points of time. And it failed spectacularly in the difficult conditions of India and Australia. Finally, McCullum had to go, after the defeat to New Zealand



Sir Gary! Sobers, the undisputed king of cricket. GETTY IMAGES

in the home series.

But, he had shown a new way to play Test cricket. That will not be forgotten.

The other high-profile Kiwi coach's departure too was perhaps as inevitable. Fleming's association had been, however, much longer, and he had become one of the faces of Chennai Super Kings. He became the CSK coach in 2009 and the following year, he led the franchise to the IPL title. He helped CSK triumph again in 2011, 2018, 2021 and 2023.

He was in Chennai all along, except in 2016 and 2017 when he moved to Rising Pune Supergiant following CSK's two-year suspension. Fleming's at CSK had one of the IPL's most successful coaching careers.

There was no IPL in Sobers' time. Even the ODIs arrived a bit too late for him (he played just one). He would have been T20 cricket's biggest superstar.

Cricket's most versatile player, who scored 8032 runs at an average of 57.78 and took 235 wickets from 93 Tests, passed away on July 17 at the age of 89.

THE GIST

- ▼ Williamson ended his international career during the Test series in England, which overlapped with the Women's World Cup
- ▼ McCullum, with Bazball, had shown a new way to play Test cricket. The other Kiwi coach's departure too was perhaps as inevitable. Fleming's association had been, however, much longer, and he had become one of the faces of Chennai Super Kings
- ▼ If things are much easier for the women cricketers of today, they owe it to players like Bates, Devine and Tahuu

India’s first dengue vaccine arrives with a crucial safety caveat

Qdenga could be responsible for enhancing dengue in children who have not had an infection yet in their lives; in such cases, the vaccine could simulate a primary dengue infection in the body, resulting in protection against DENV-1 and DENV-2 infections but not against a DENV-3 infection

Swaminathan S

India’s drug regulator just approved the country’s first dengue vaccine, Qdenga. It is designed and claimed to protect against the four serotypes of the dengue-causing virus, called DENV-1 to DENV-4. Young children as well as adults (aged 4-60 years), irrespective of whether they have had dengue before, may be vaccinated with Qdenga.

More than 40 countries have already approved Qdenga, which is manufactured by the Japanese pharmaceutical company Takeda. That said, data from clinical trials that Takeda published in 2019, 2020, and 2024 on the vaccine’s efficacy raise a specific concern about its abilities.

Rationale of dengue vaccines

All the four DENV serotypes are prevalent in India. Each serotype is different from the other such that an immune response to one may not necessarily protect against another. A person who has experienced a natural dengue infection will carry antibodies to the specific DENV serotype in their serum, and the person will be said to be seropositive. A person who has not been exposed to a natural DENV infection will not carry dengue antibodies and is said to be seronegative.

When a seronegative person contracts a first DENV infection for the first time, they will develop antibodies to that particular DENV serotype. When this person, seropositive for that particular DENV serotype, suffers a second infection by another DENV serotype, there is a non-zero chance that they may experience severe dengue. This is because the antibodies produced against the first DENV serotype may actually enhance infection by the second DENV serotype. This is called antibody-dependent enhancement (ADE).

The holy grail of dengue vaccines is to avoid ADE. Any safe and effective vaccine for dengue must be ‘tetravalent’ – meaning it must target all four DENV serotypes simultaneously and equally. If a dengue vaccine fails to protect against even one serotype, it will keep the door open to ADE in future.

It is quite clear that the efficacy and safety of a dengue vaccine are linked to each other as two sides of the same coin. And Qdenga’s phase-3 trial efficacy data need to be understood through this lens.

Phase-3 trial

Takeda set up a large phase-3 trial involving around 20,000 healthy children (4-16 years old) across eight Latin American and Asian countries where dengue is endemic to assess Qdenga’s safety and efficacy. The results from this trial were first published in 2019, with additional data published in 2020 and



The efficacy and safety of a dengue vaccine are linked to each other as two sides of the same coin, and Qdenga’s phase-3 trial data need to be understood through this lens. GETTY IMAGES

2024. Around two-thirds of the children in the trial received Qdenga while the remaining third received a saline solution. Then the researchers compared the vaccine efficacy between the two groups. The efficacy was defined to mean the ability of Qdenga to prevent dengue infections and resultant hospitalisation.

If the vaccine worked as intended, one would expect fewer cases of dengue in the vaccinated group versus in the unvaccinated group. And this was true. In the vaccinated group, five children out of 1,000 contracted a DENV infection while in the unvaccinated group, 24 children per 1,000 contracted a DENV infection. This translates to an overall efficacy of about 80%.

Overall, Takeda’s investigators stratified their participants into seropositive and seronegative groups before administering the vaccine. The efficacy was about 82% and 75% in these two groups, respectively. These seem like solid numbers – but the devil is in the details.

‘Variable VE’

If you look at the results stratified by DENV serotype as well, a particular granular detail, which could actually be a potential safety signal, emerges. In children who were seronegative prior to vaccination, those susceptible to DENV-3 infection were noticeably more numerous in the vaccinated group than in the unvaccinated group. In other words, seronegative children vaccinated with

The consequences of contracting a secondary DENV-4 infection by seronegative children cannot be predicted since we do not know of Qdenga’s efficacy against DENV-4; in India, the number of such children facing this risk could be very large

Qdenga were 25% more likely to be infected by DENV-3 relative to unvaccinated children.

The number of DENV-4 cases during the trial were so low (in the seropositive group) or totally absent (in the seronegative group) that the efficacy of Qdenga for DENV-4 is essentially unknown. The efficacy was high against DENV-1 and -2, irrespective of the serostatus at baseline.

The investigators had consistently noted these observations in Takeda’s 2020 and 2024 papers as well.

They also persistently referred to this feature of their vaccine as “variable VE against the different serotypes” and described it as a “numerical imbalance” in the number of dengue infections.

The data clearly demonstrate that Qdenga does not offer protection against DENV-3 and could in fact actually be responsible for enhancing dengue in children who have not had a dengue infection yet in their lives. In such cases, Qdenga – being a live dengue vaccine – could simulate a primary dengue

infection in the body, resulting in protection against DENV-1 and DENV-2 infections – but not against a DENV-3 infection.

And if such children were to contract a natural DENV-3 infection, they will have a 25% higher likelihood of falling sick, as this will be a secondary dengue infection linked to potential ADE.

Need for screening

The consequences of contracting a secondary DENV-4 infection by such children cannot be predicted since we do not know of Qdenga’s efficacy against DENV-4. At a conservative estimate of 40 million children in India, with only under 30% of them estimated to be seropositive for dengue, the number of seronegative children facing this heightened risk could be very large.

In a paper in *Nature Medicine* on July 25, researchers from Imperial College London modelled the health impact of Qdenga in a population and concluded that it would be safer for seronegative recipients – especially children – to be screened for prior dengue exposure before receiving the shot.

In sum, ignoring the DENV-3 safety signal in seronegative children could be a costly and avoidable mistake, and should be avoided through screening.

S. Swaminathan is retired professor of biology from BITS Pilani-Hyderabad and a former scientist in the area of dengue vaccinology at ICGEB, New Delhi. (ssn225@gmail.com)

THE GIST

Qdenga is designed and claimed to protect against the four serotypes of the dengue-causing virus, called DENV-1 to DENV-4

Data from clinical trials that Takeda published in 2019, 2020, and 2024 on the vaccine’s efficacy raise a specific concern about its abilities

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BIG SHOT



Experts from the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts use a portable X-ray fluorescence analyser to examine the pigments, material composition and condition of centuries-old frescoes during their scientific documentation and conservation at Amer Fort, in Jaipur, Rajasthan, on July 24. PTI

WHAT IS IT?

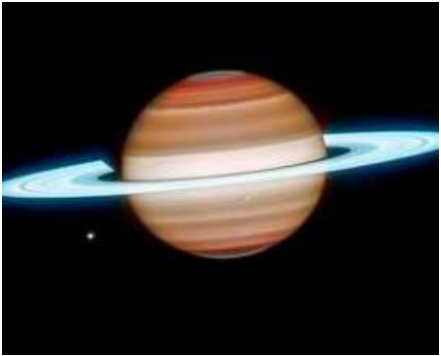
PRAXIS: grazing planet rings

Vasudevan Mukunth

PRAXIS is an acronym of ‘Planetary Rings Autonomous Exploration with In-situ Sampling’. NASA has just selected a mission concept called ‘PRAXIS’ for its Innovative Advanced Concepts (NIAC) 2026 phase I funding.

The mission will consist of a bio-inspired robotic explorer driven by an artificial intelligence (AI) model. It will be capable of directly sampling particles from planetary ring systems – something no mission has ever attempted before. The mission’s selection for NIAC was guided by open questions in the science of planets’ rings that NASA’s Planetary Science Decadal Survey has flagged as important.

These questions include how planetary rings form, how they evolve, and what ring particles are made of. Rather than fly through a ring – which would pose collision hazards – PRAXIS currently plans to just graze the ring plane. Specifically, once it has picked a target particle, the spacecraft will perform a touch-and-go sample of the particle’s surface using a long deployable boom, staying at a safe distance from the moving ring particles. Once it has a sample, the craft will move on to another region or gap in the rings to sample from another area. When it has a sample, small instruments will snag free-floating particles and the



James Webb Space Telescope’s view of Saturn’s atmosphere. SPACE TELESCOPE SCIENCE INSTITUTE/NASA

AI model will help measure particle size, porosity, and composition. Being selected for NIAC phase-I finding means the PRAXIS team can start running simulations and studying system design. If the idea advances to phase II, the team can start building a physical prototype. According to its developers, the PRAXIS sampling system can be used in missions to study many ringed planets.



For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of Delhi schools found with safety deficiencies

774 Private schools accounted for the highest number of cases. According to a statement from Lok Nivas, 1,677 schools were inspected between July 13 and 24. Safety deficiencies were found in 270 government schools, 463 private schools and 41 government-aided schools. PTI

People still affected by the Assam flood situation

6.5 in lakh. The flood situation in Assam improved on Sunday as water levels were receding in most of the affected areas with those places not receiving overnight rainfall, even as over 6.5 lakh people remained hit in six districts and 66 people lost their lives in this year's deluge. PTI

People evacuated in South China due to Typhoon Noul landfall

3.4 in lakh. Typhoon Noul made landfall early Sunday and was bringing winds and heavy rain to southern China, including Hong Kong. China's weather centre said Noul made landfall along the coast of Huidong county of the city of Huizhou in the southern Guangdong province. PTI

Number of people evacuated from the biggest forest fire

2.2 in lakh. French authorities said that more than 2,20,000 people have been evacuated from the forest fire raging in the southwest of the country that has also forced the closure of highways and rail lines. More than 50,000 people have also been ordered to leave villages around Bordeaux. AFP

Maharashtra: share of SIR enumeration forms distributed

87.8 Maharashtra has distributed 87.79% of enumeration forms and digitised 60.44% of them under the ongoing SIR of electoral rolls, officials said. The enumeration phase is being carried out from June 30 to August 8. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Why is China's AI push gaining ground?

How have Chinese firms caught up with leading U.S. AI models despite chip restrictions? What advantages do Chinese open-source AI models offer over captive models? How has Beijing supported the growth? What challenges could China face in the future?

EXPLAINER

Aroon Deep

The story so far:

A matter of weeks after Anthropic's Fable AI model was launched to great acclaim, Chinese firm Moonshot AI released Kimi K3, a model that has measured up to the Claude model in most parameters. The notable factor here is that K3, and a clutch of other models made in China, are open-weight and/or open-source, meaning that any company (or well-resourced individual) can run them locally.

How is China positioning itself in AI?

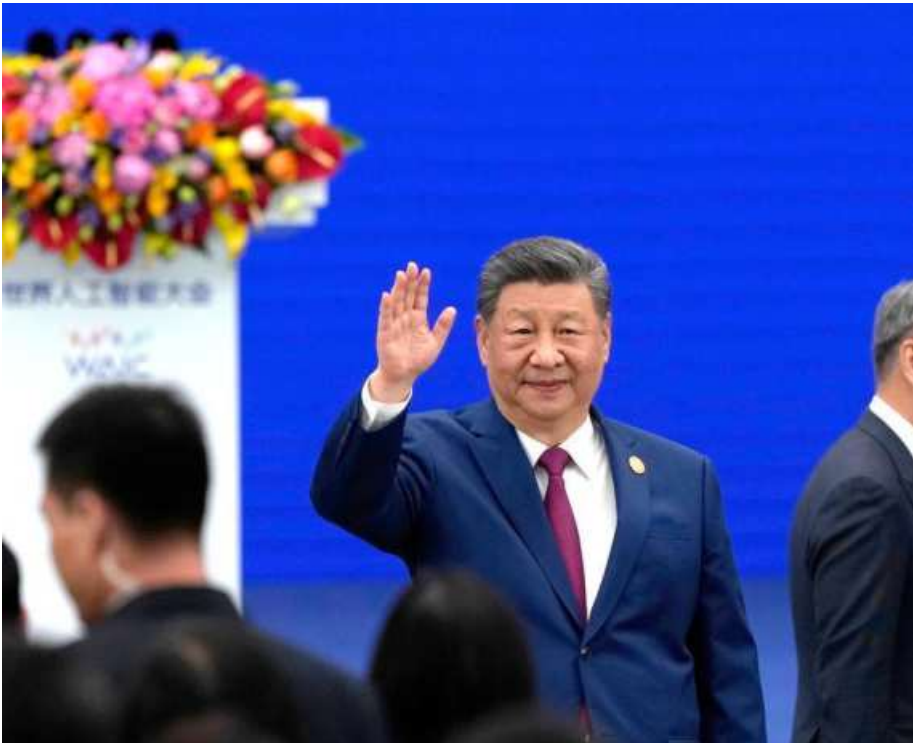
At the Shanghai World AI Conference on July 17, Chinese president Xi Jinping said that with AI, countries "should adhere to the principle of openness and win-win and boost innovation-driven development". At least as far as the currently available open models are concerned, Chinese firms are walking that talk.

China faces crucial restrictions on graphics processing units (GPUs) that are required for training AI models and running queries (inference) on them. However, China has bridged this gap with abundant electricity access and a larger quantity of less advanced chips. The result is models like Kimi K3, which is a 2.8 trillion parameter model.

How have they built a competitive ecosystem?

Not all open-source models are designed for those many parameters; Alibaba, the retail and e-commerce giant that is now growing significant in-house AI capabilities, has put out several lightweight models that have impressed AI enthusiasts who prefer to run inference on their own hardware.

China has supported AI research labs as well as encouraged existing large firms like Tencent and Baidu to work on AI,



Gearing up: Chinese president Xi Jinping; China's results are indicative of long-term planning that it had set in motion for the AI ecosystem. AP

which has resulted in a multiplicity of models that have been downloaded millions of times from platforms like HuggingFace, with developers enthusiastically adopting these models for narrow, tailored use-cases.

One of the most well-known entrants that challenged U.S. dominance is the startup DeepSeek, whose models are available online as well as on an open-source basis. The Chinese government has also acted to protect these firms from being co-opted into the U.S.-led AI ecosystem, such as by restricting travel for key personnel and blocking Facebook parent Meta's acquisition of the firm Manus.

What does this mean for the global race?

The difference between open-source and captive models – Anthropic and OpenAI's

models, as well as most of Google's, land in the latter category – is that source code is not freely shared with the broader AI developer ecosystem, giving firms a theoretical edge. But another key difference that could counteract that advantage is that open-source models can be run by third-party providers who compete with others like them to provide greater cost predictability.

This is so far a theoretical advantage, since the U.S.'s frontier firms are greatly subsidising their models; Anthropic is this month giving out \$100 in credits to paying users to use their Fable model. But once that exuberance dies down, the focus may very well shift to infrastructure providers, who may find open-source models an attractive offering.

This is, of course, assuming that open-source models continue to be provided freely by Chinese firms in the

coming months and years. Alibaba has already started working on captive AI models that run on its own infrastructure and are not open-source.

Since open-source models are expensive to produce, it may not be a given that they will be trained at the same clip, as the companies most capable of making them may change business models.

Chinese firms have caught up in capability, but there remains a trust deficit, especially in India, on using their models. Open-sourcing models means that local firms running on inference aggregators like Neysa and even the IT Ministry's Computer Emergency Response Team (CERT-in) make use of these models, since no question of data leakage emerges.

The bet may very well be that once the open-source honeymoon ends, and the world has seen how good Chinese models are compared to the most advanced Western counterparts, captive models may get a second consideration, even allowing for the geopolitical baggage that comes with embracing Chinese technology.

Things may not necessarily move in that direction, as the existing models and their accompanying literature are being studied by researchers and labs around the world.

The geopolitical baggage has likely been a major reason why India, despite hosting the AI Impact Summit in February, skipped out on the Shanghai conference. The government is trying to encourage domestic champions and hold off Chinese capital in Indian AI by promoting firms like Sarvam AI in spite of scarce resources. However, as noted above, open-source models have not been discouraged.

China's results are indicative of long-term planning that its government had set in motion for the AI ecosystem.

The next major focus area, Mr. Jinping indicated in his speech, was AI "moving from the digital world into the physical world."

THE GIST

China's open-source AI push has rapidly narrowed the capability gap with U.S. frontier models, backed by State support, efficient use of computing resources, and a growing ecosystem of developers and firms.

While open models could reshape the global AI market through lower-cost deployment, questions over long-term business models, geopolitical trust, and India's push for domestic AI champions will influence their adoption.

Why has India moved to take down BitChat repositories?

What is BitChat? Can communication tools be blocked for their potential misuse?

Rizmi Lia M.

The story so far:

The Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C), under the Ministry of Home Affairs, directed GitHub on July 23 to remove repositories hosting BitChat, the Bluetooth mesh messaging application developed by X co-founder Jack Dorsey, stating that the app could be exploited to coordinate unlawful assemblies and circumvent lawful restrictions imposed by competent authorities during situations involving public order. The order comes at a time when repeated internet shutdowns near protest sites have led protesters to increasingly rely on Bluetooth-enabled messaging platforms such as BitChat for communication.

What is BitChat?

BitChat is a decentralised peer-to-peer messaging application that operates over Bluetooth mesh networks. It requires no

internet connection, no servers and no phone numbers.

Traditional messaging apps depend on centralised infrastructure that can be monitored, censored or disabled. BitChat creates ad hoc communication networks using only devices in physical proximity, with each device acting as both a client and a server, automatically discovering peers and relaying messages across multiple hops to extend the network's reach.

According to the platform, this approach provides censorship resistance, surveillance resistance and infrastructure independence. The network remains functional during internet outages, natural disasters, protests, or in regions with limited connectivity.

What does the order say?

The order directs GitHub to disable access to three repositories, including the Android application and its release files, within three hours.

It also warns that failure to comply

could invite criminal prosecution.

According to the order, the application enables anonymous communication without mandatory user registration, phone number verification or centralised logging of communications. It states that the application's technical architecture significantly impedes lawful interception, attribution and investigation by law enforcement agencies.

It further states that since communications occur directly between nearby devices through a decentralised mesh network, the platform can be misused to evade lawful surveillance, facilitate anonymous coordination and circumvent lawful restrictions imposed by competent authorities during situations involving public order, riots, terrorism, organised crime or internet shutdowns.

The order also states that "such decentralised communication platforms are capable of being exploited for coordinating unlawful assemblies, violent protests, dissemination of misinformation, radicalisation, criminal

conspiracies, and other activities prejudicial to the sovereignty and integrity of India, defence of India, security of the State, public order, and for facilitating the commission of cognizable offences."

What does the law say?

The order, Notice No. 11072601011432, was issued at 11.16 p.m. on July 23 under Section 79(3)(b) of the Information Technology Act, 2000, read with Rule 3(1)(d) of the Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Rules, 2021.

Section 79(3)(b) provides that an intermediary may lose its safe harbour protection if, upon receiving actual knowledge or being notified by the appropriate government or its agency that any information, data or communication link residing in or connected to a computer resource controlled by the intermediary is being used to commit an unlawful act, it fails to expeditiously remove or disable access to that material without vitiating the evidence in any manner.

However, Section 79 itself does not confer a blocking power. Blocking directions are ordinarily issued under Section 69A of the IT Act and the Blocking Rules, 2009, which require a hearing and reasons recorded in writing, subject to review.

It empowers the Union government to direct the blocking of public access to information on grounds such as national

security, public order and the prevention of incitement to the commission of cognisable offences. Such orders are required to follow the procedure prescribed under the law.

Why is the order being criticised?

The Internet Freedom Foundation (IFF) criticised the order, arguing that it relies on the application's potential for misuse rather than identifying any unlawful content hosted in the repositories. "Anticipated misuse of a communications tool is not a lawful basis to prohibit the tool," the organisation said.

The order directs GitHub to "remove and disable access to the concerned URLs within three hours of the issue of this communication without vitiating evidence in any manner."

According to IFF, the notice, issued close to midnight, fails the proportionality standard laid down by the Supreme Court in *Anuradha Bhasin v. Union of India* (2020).

In *Anuradha Bhasin*, the Supreme Court held that "the degree of restriction and the scope of the same, both territorially and temporally, must stand in relation to what is actually necessary to combat an emergent situation." The court observed that the principle of proportionality requires restrictions to be tailored to the territorial extent of the restriction, the stage of the emergency, the nature of the urgency, the nature of the restrictive measure and the nature of the restriction.

